



CHENNAI

TNRERA/29/BLG/0027/2026
DATED 27.01.2026



PRESTIGE, PRIVILEGE
AND POWER.

EXPERIENCE
THE ART OF

fine living.

✦ LAUNCHING ✦



ROSENDALE
BESANT NAGAR



✦ LAUNCHING ✦



ROSENDALE

BESANT NAGAR

Welcome home to Rosendale by Tulive GK Shetty,
a luxurious collection of 10 homes set in cosy
Besant Nagar. Experience a lifestyle crafted
for those who value space, privacy, and quiet,
in these 4-bed residences nestled within lush
greenery on the tranquil Beach Road.

 8010 976 976

 www.tulivegkshetty.com



Scan to chat on WhatsApp



INBRIEF



National conference on sepsis care and management held

A two-day national academic programme on sepsis diagnosis and management called “SRM SEPSICON 2026” was conducted by SRM Medical College Hospital and Research Centre on March 17 and 18. The programme included hands-on workshops on infection control, antimicrobial stewardship and advanced blood diagnostic techniques. Participants took part in case-based discussions, laboratory demonstrations and audit-based learning sessions. Rahul Narang, Dean (Research) and Professor and Head, Department of Microbiology, AIIMS Bibinagar, spoke about the need for integrated approaches in healthcare, highlighting collaboration across disciplines. Nithin M. Nagarkar, Pro-Vice Chancellor (MHS), SRMIST, said multidisciplinary coordination among clinicians, microbiologists and researchers remains key to effective care. R. Jayanthi, Dean (Medical), SRM Medical College Hospital and Research Centre, K. V. Leela, Associate Dean (UG Academics) and Head, Department of Microbiology also spoke.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (March 19, Thursday), the following articles are available:

- What is new in transgender rights Bill? newsth.live/transrightslaw
- India's frogs are finding allies from citizen science to sanctuaries newsth.live/frogday

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Backlogs for LPG refills range from 4 to 12 days: distributors

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With restrictions continuing on bookings of cooking gas cylinders, distributors say they have been concentrating on clearing backlogs with the limited quantity of refills. Depending on the company and the agency, backlogs have come down and vary from four days to 12 days. “Panic bookings have come down mainly due to the restrictions and also since we have been able to make deliveries. People now are coming to the agency to find out when they will get their cylinders. They don't yell and shout any more,” said a distributor in the city. Distributors and company staff, whose patience has been stretched thin

since the liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) shortage hit, have been saying that they now shudder at the sight of a mobile call. “After last week, people fell sick. Just in one day we received 6,000 bookings. One agency I know got over 3,500 bookings in just four hours. But we are unable to deliver refills since we are getting only about 50%-80% of our usual quota,” said a distributor.

Difficult situation

The distributors in rural and hilly area are in an even more difficult situation as their customers have to wait for 45 days before a booking can be made. “Yesterday, a customer came to our office with her baby saying her cylinder was empty. She was in tears, saying that

without LPG she was unable to provide milk to the infant. The single load of cylinders that I received was taken away by those who had booked as soon as the batch landed. The woman had received her refill 37 days ago. So, I told her to wait for seven more days to make a booking,” said a distributor.

Upon suspending connections of those who had not booked gas refills for nine months, consumer activist T. Sadagopan said oil marketing companies had not even intimidated the consumers. “Only when they try to book refills, will they find out that they cannot and will have to go to their respective agency and submit KYC to reactivate the connection. This amounts to deficiency of service,” he added.

☀️ Timings
CHENNAI

THURSDAY, MAR. 19		
☀️ RISE	06:14	SET 18:20
☀️ RISE	06:13	SET 18:40
FRIDAY, MAR. 20		
☀️ RISE	06:13	SET 18:20
☀️ RISE	06:54	SET 19:36
SATURDAY, MAR. 21		
☀️ RISE	06:13	SET 18:20
☀️ RISE	07:38	SET 20:34

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	34	21
Chennai Airport	34	24
Chennai City	32	24

Chennai Airport Today
34°C Morning will be pleasant. Day will be warm. Night also will be pleasant. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be dry. Day will be warm. Night will be pleasant.

© Copyright Skymet Weather 2026
All rights reserved.

Civic issues take centre stage as electors call for permanent solutions, improved security

The DMK stronghold is set for a 4-cornered contest, with the ruling party and its allies, the AIADMK and BJP, TVK, and NTK in the fray. A few party representatives say they expect a narrow victory margin as it is likely that voters aged 18-30 may back parties such as TVK over the Dravidian majors

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

As the Greater Chennai Police and the Central Reserve Police Force conducted a flag march on a congested stretch in the vicinity of the Chepauk Palace in Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni Assembly constituency on Wednesday, Samsath Begum, 64, sat on the footpath, selling clothes amid the haphazardly parked vehicles near her residence.

“I have been requesting a new mobile vending cart for my business from the MLA. I have also submitted an application for the *Kalaignar Magalir Urimai Thittam*,” she said. Pointing to the loss of livelihood of many vendors in the constituency, she said: “Many poor residents in our constituency depend on financial assistance from the government. I have yet to receive ₹5,000 from the State government. But I will still vote for the DMK because of their welfare schemes.”

Ahead of the election, voters in the DMK stronghold highlighted the prevalent civic issues, including inadequate parking spaces, large scale unauthorised development of commercial buildings

Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni

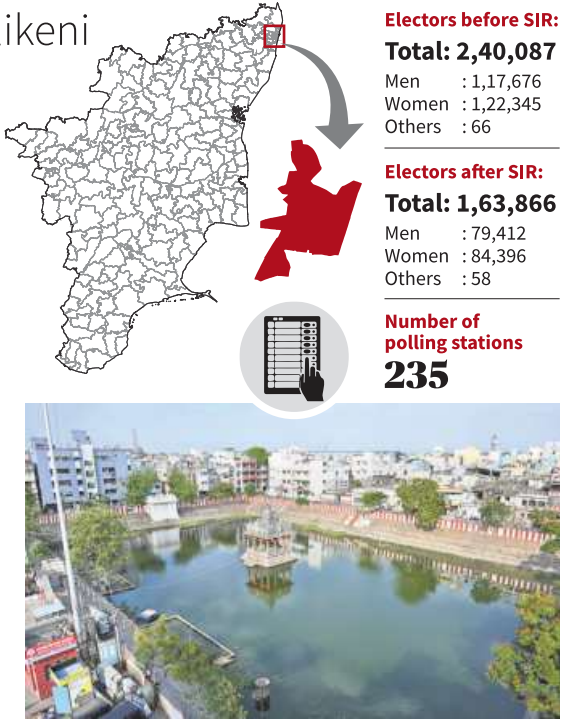
As a way to boost their livelihood, many electors involved in commercial activities in the densely-populated region have demanded that the Marina Beach be improved to attract tourists from around the world

WARDS

62, 63, 114, 115, 116, 119, and 120

- Civic issues**
- Unauthorised parking of cars by pilgrims visiting places of worship in the area
 - Increase in traffic congestion
 - No bus connectivity to several major areas of the city
 - Poor infrastructure near MRTS stations in the constituency
 - Large scale unauthorised development of commercial buildings
 - Inadequate sewage treatment

2021 Assembly election result:
Udhayanidhi Stalin of the DMK defeated Kassali A.V.A. of the PMK by a margin of **69,355 votes**



Long-standing problem: Residents complain that illegal sewage connections of commercial establishments have been polluting the tank of the Sri Parthasarathy Temple in Triplicane. M. SRINATH

mercial buildings in old ‘continuous building’ residential areas, illegal parking of vehicles along the road, security issues, and encroachments on congested stretches.

Traffic congestion

Roads such as Quaid E Milath Road, Barathi Salai, and Zam Bazaar have registered a rise in traffic congestion in recent times. Reiterating the negative

impact of the unauthorised parking of vehicles by pilgrims who visit places of worship in the area, A.V. Kasturi Rangan of Triplicane said: “Five years ago, we had demanded a solution to the parking issue in the vicinity of the Sri Parthasarathy Temple. The MLA was expected to find a lasting solution, and construct parking lots for pilgrims’ vehicles. Pilgrims park vehicles right in front

of gates of residences.” Traffic congestion near the Big Mosque is also a major problem.

Stray cattle menace

Resident and social worker T.J. Ramani said the civic issues, including stray cattle, had not been resolved because of a delay in the construction of a shelter for stray cattle in the constituency. “The government has

not constructed a multi-level parking lot for vehicles near the Sri Parthasarathy Temple. Infrastructure needs to be improved for the safety and security of residents, particularly working professionals and students using the Triplicane MRTS station. The bus service from Ice House to T. Nagar has been completely withdrawn. Now residents of the constituency do not have bus connectivity from Ice House via Mylapore to T. Nagar. Frequency of buses such as 45A, 24A, 24C, and 29D should be increased,” Mr. Ramani added.

Residents also complained about pollution in the Sri Parthasarathy Temple tank due to illegal sewage connections from commercial establishments in the storm-water drains. Inadequate sewage treatment in the densely populated constituency remains another challenge.

V.P. Mani, president of the Thiruvallikeni Traders’ Association, said the MLA had taken measures to fulfil the demands of the traders in the constituency, including simplifying the procedure for the renewal of trade licences with the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC). “After the government is formed, we request the GCC to install closed-circuit television camera surveillance for the

safety and security of the traders,” he said.

Following the Special Intensive Revision, 76,221 voters in the constituency have been removed from the electoral roll. Political functionaries of various parties in the constituency have been sensitising electors to submit Form 6 for the inclusion of their names on the electoral rolls.

Expecting a four-cornered contest of the DMK and allies, the AIADMK and the BJP, the TVK, and the NTK in the constituency, a few party representatives said they expected electors aged between 18 and 30, including those from Scheduled Caste and minority communities, to support an alternative party, such as the TVK, over the two Dravidian majors, pointing to the possibility of a much narrower victory than last time for Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin, if the party decides to field him in this constituency again.

However, DMK party representatives said the cadre was optimistic of yet another victory by a huge margin in 2026 owing to implementation of a large number of civic infrastructure projects, including housing for the poor and libraries for students’ welfare in low-income neighbourhoods.

CLASSIFIEDS MART

TO ADVERTISE VISIT
www.thehinduads.com
CALL: 044-28576300 • TOLL FREE: 1800 102 4161
or Contact your nearest Authorised space sellers

PERSONAL	FINANCIAL
CHANGE OF NAME	FURNITURE
I, S.GOKUL, s/o Selvaraj DOB:15-12-1999 Native: Avadi residing at 10 Govindasamy Street Govarthana Giri, Kamaraj Nagar Thiruvallur 600071. Shall henceforth be known as Gokul Selvaraj - S.Gokul	BANK DSA Organise MSME Fresh, Takeover Loans from Banks : 9444481740
PAINTINGS	TENDERS
I, ALL SOFAS, All Recliners,Recondition,Reupholstery KNS Rajan 7667133233	PAINTING, WATERPROOFING Leakage, Seepage,Crack arrest ct:9940037740
OLD AGE HOME	E-TENDER NOTICE
I, PALLIATIVE CARE at your home Trained Nurses, 24/7, Dr., Physio visits, Lab tests 1800-313-1883 tikotra.com/seniors	Competitive E-Tenders are invited for the Printing and Supply of Answer Booklets. Last date: 30/03/2026 at 03:00 PM. Tender ID: 2026_KUHS_847349_1. For more details: Log on to: www.etenders.kerala.gov.in or call 0487-220 777, 7740. REGISTRAR
AUTOMOTIVE	
SELL YOUR car at Best Price Lanson Toyota U Trust Contact 9941655937	
BUSINESS OFFERS	
INVESTOR/PARTNER REQ 20Language OTT&Film Distribution Proj. 8148188460	

CLASSIFIEDS SPECIAL

SINCE : 1988

MAAN SAROVAR Offers

Unbelievable Prices!

Raymond Export Surplus Suitings

Arvind Mills 100% Cotton Shirts & Suitings

McKenry The Absolute Man | **Siyaram's** Bamboo Shirting

• SHIRTING • SUITING • TROUSERS • SHIRTS • T-SHIRTS

GUILD OF SERVICE

28, Casa Major Road, Egmore, (Near Don Bosco School) Chennai.

SUPPLY WORKS

E-Tenders are invited by the undersigned for the following works: **Tender No. DB265084 Dated: 16-03-2026. PL Code (Group): 459021660020.**

Name of work: Roof mounted AC Package units RMPU type-1 for LHB AC coaches. Each set consisting of RMPU with R-407C Refrigerant(1 set= 2 nos RMPU) to RDSO Spec. no. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0061-2005 Rev-1 and 1(One) number microprocessor unit as RDSO Spec. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0139-2009 or latest. Make: RDSO Approved only. [Warranty Period: 30 Months after the date of delivery]. **Earnest Money:** ₹5,70,050/- **E-tender will be closed at 14:30 hrs. on 13-04-2026.** The complete information of above e-tender will be available in website www.ireps.gov.in

Dy.Chief Material Manager/Dibrugarh

NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

THE MUSIC ACADEMY, MADRAS
(Phones: 28112231 / 28115162)

Nadotsavam 2026
(An exclusive Nagaswaram Festival)
at The Kasturi Srinivasan Hall

Date	5.15 p.m. – 6.45 p.m.	7.00 p.m. – 8.30 p.m.
Mar. 23, Mon	Tirupananthol Viswanathan & Vijayalakshmi (Nagaswaram), Achalapuram A. V. Selvam (Thavil), Tiruvengadu T. M. Guhan (Thavil).	Guruvilli Appanna Rao (Nagaswaram), Guruvilli Durga Rao (Thavil), Cuddapah D. V. Ramasubbiah (Thavil).
Mar. 24, Tue	Thirumanur Brothers T. K. Karthikeyan & T. K. Kameshwaran (Nagaswaram), Mandaveli S. Mohanraj (Thavil), Mayiladuthurai SRDM B. Muthukumar (Thavil).	Sembanarkoil S. R. G. S. Mohandoss (Nagaswaram), Mylai K. Selvam (Nagaswaram), Swamimalai C. Gurunathan (Thavil), Sivanvoyal S. M. Rajarathinam (Thavil).
Mar. 25, Wed	Pazhayaseevaram K. Kalidass (Nagaswaram), Koleri G. Vinoth Kumar (Nagaswaram), Tirukkadaiyur T. G. Babu (Thavil), Panapakkam G. Tamizhselvan (Thavil).	Vadassery Brothers T. Sethumadhavan & T. V. Sivadasan (Nagaswaram), Poondi T. G. Udayashankar (Thavil), Pollachi S. Sivasankar (Thavil).

Sponsored by **Ramco Industries Limited**

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy, Madras
Today: 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall – Nagaswaram Concert - Thirumakalam T.S. Pandian & Guruvayur S. Sreeram (Nagaswaram), Villupuram K.S. Kamaraj & Vedaranyam V.L. Harish (Thavil) – programme under the endowment instituted by families of Sri. Narayan Nadadhur & Sri. Srinivasan Nadadhur in the name of their parents, Smt. Rajamma and Sri. N. Gopalaswami, former CEC.

Today at 5 pm Tulsidas Ramcharitramanas Tamil, Madurai Sivaganes - Vocal, Shradha Ravindran - Violin, Thillaisthanam Suriyanarayana - Mridangam. 6.30pm Kulasekara Alvar's Rama Commentary by Madhusudan Kalaichelvan Music by Ariyakudi Ramanuja Iyengar & BV Raman Lakshmanan Navaneeth Krishnan - Vocal Nerukuntam Shankar - Khanjira. Ph. No: 86105 57987. Rasikas welcome.

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4

To advertise visit www.thehinduads.com
044-28576300 Toll Free: 1800 102 4161

21.3.2026 6.00 PM KAMARAJ ARANGAM
TICKETS 98841 52200
www.bookmyshow.com

MISCELLANEOUS

Sringeri Bharathi Vidyashram, T.Nagar, Ph: 24348964.
H.H.Sringeri Jagadguru Sri Bharati Tirtha Mahasannidhanam 76 th Vardhanti / Sri Ramanavami Mahotsavam 2026 Today Ugadi- Telugu New Year's Day, Eve. 5.00pm Perabava Varusha Panchanga Patanam in Telugu by Sri. Aswini Sastrigal Group. All are welcome.

S. R. RAGHUNATHAN


THE HINDU GROUP



VIT[®]
Vellore Institute of Technology
(Deemed to be University under section 3 of UGC Act, 1956)

Presents

— THE HINDU —
EDUCATIONPLUS
CAREER PATH SERIES

A WEBINAR ON

**NEXT-GEN ENGINEERING CAREERS:
OPPORTUNITIES & SKILLS FOR THE FUTURE**



Dr Sandhya Pentareddy
Executive Director,
VIT, Vellore



Dr Samuel Rajkumar
Director - Career Development Centre,
VIT, Vellore



Pavan Desiraju
Head - Human Resources,
Sandisk



Soma Basu
Journalist, Moderator

Friday, March 20, 2026 | 4:00 pm onwards

To register, visit:
newsth.live/THVITNGP
or scan the QR code



Investigation against MP Navas Kani has begun, Income Tax Dept. tells Madras HC

“The increase in assets during a five-year period is extraordinary and steep. Shri Navas Kani has created these considerable assets by misusing his official position. Given his minimal legitimate income, he has illegally enriched himself misappropriating public funds assigned to Members of Parliament for the development of their constituencies, thereby defrauding the nation’s exchequer. The assets acquired by him are disproportionate to all his known sources of income,” the petitioner’s affidavit read.

Kathir, coordinator of a non-governmental organisation Evidence, said a representation with over 4,000 pages detailing the various judgments of cases of honour killings carried out in the State and the country had been handed over to Justice Basha. Viduthalaai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) leader and Nagapattinam MLA Mohamed Shahnawas and social activists were present.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY				
SCHEDULE OF E-AUCTION NOTICE (SCRAP SALE)				
Schedule E-Auction time from 10.00 AM to 05.00 PM				
Month	Division	Date & Day		Mobile
APRIL 2026	Pt. Deen Dayal Udhapuray	06.04.2026 (Monday), 13.04.2026 (Monday), 20.04.2026 (Monday), 27.04.2026 (Monday)		9794848770
	Dhanbad	07.04.2026 (Tuesday), 13.04.2026 (Monday), 21.04.2026 (Tuesday), 28.04.2026 (Tuesday)		9771426770
	Danapur	08.04.2026 (Wednesday), 16.04.2026 (Thursday), 22.04.2026 (Wednesday), 29.04.2026 (Wednesday)		9771449770
	Samastipur	09.04.2026 (Thursday), 16.04.2026 (Thursday), 23.04.2026 (Thursday), 30.04.2026 (Thursday)		9771428770
	Sonepur	02.04.2026 (Thursday), 10.04.2026 (Friday), 17.04.2026 (Friday), 24.04.2026 (Friday)		9771429770
	Harnaut	07.04.2026 (Tuesday), 13.04.2026 (Monday), 21.04.2026 (Tuesday), 28.04.2026 (Tuesday)		9771452206
	Pt. Deen Dayal Udhapuray	04.05.2026 (Monday), 11.05.2026 (Monday), 18.05.2026 (Monday), 25.05.2026 (Monday)		9794848770
	Dhanbad	05.05.2026 (Tuesday), 12.05.2026 (Tuesday), 19.05.2026 (Tuesday), 26.05.2026 (Tuesday)		9771426770
MAY 2026	Danapur	06.05.2026 (Wednesday), 13.05.2026 (Wednesday), 20.05.2026 (Wednesday), 28.05.2026 (Thursday)		9771449770
	Samastipur	07.05.2026 (Thursday), 14.05.2026 (Thursday), 21.05.2026 (Thursday), 28.05.2026 (Thursday)		9771428770
	Sonepur	08.05.2026 (Friday), 15.05.2026 (Friday), 22.05.2026 (Friday), 29.05.2026 (Friday)		9771429770
	Harnaut	05.05.2026 (Tuesday), 12.05.2026 (Tuesday), 19.05.2026 (Tuesday), 26.05.2026 (Tuesday)		9771452206

INBRIEF



A.P. CM launches free bus travel for differently abled

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Wednesday launched the ‘Divyang Shakti’ scheme, which offers free bus travel to differently abled persons. Accompanied by Deputy Chief Minister K. Pawan Kalyan, HRD Minister Nara Lokesh and beneficiaries, Mr. Naidu travelled 11 km in a bus. Under the scheme, those with more than 40% disability can travel free of cost in APSRTC buses. Attendants will get a 50 per cent concession on the fare.

Drug trafficking network busted, foreign nationals held

In a major crackdown, the Karnataka Police’s Central Crime Branch (CCB) Anti Narcotics Wing unearthed an international drug trafficking network operating through foreign postal channels and arrested several accused, including three foreign nationals. CCB officials conducted an operation at a foreign post office in Bengaluru and intercepted suspicious parcels from abroad. They seized 2.865 kg of hydro ganja, 108 gm of MDMA, and 2 gm of cocaine.

Three MBBS students killed in accident in Kozhikode

Three MBBS students from Malabar Medical College were killed in a road accident at Kuruvangad, near Koyilandy, in Kozhikode district of Kerala early on Wednesday. The deceased were identified as Nandakishore, 22, of Karunagappally, Abhiyan Rahman of Kayamkulam, and Abhinav Suresh, 20 of Alanelur. The accident took place when the electric scooter they were travelling on crashed into an electric post and fell into a nearby drain.

Cong. second Kerala list in limbo as MPs wish to fight

Kannur MP Sudhakaran reiterates demand for ticket in Assembly polls; AICC chief clarifies that MPs will not contest State elections; meetings inconclusive; party leaders divided on the issue

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Congress candidate selection for the remaining 40 Assembly seats appeared to be in limbo with K. Sudhakaran, Kannur MP and former Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president, refusing to back down from his demand to be fielded from the Kannur constituency for the April 9 election.

The Congress, which heads the Opposition United Democratic Front, released its first list of 55 candidates on Tuesday.

After several rounds of meetings, the central election committee of the par-



K. Sudhakaran is presently camping in New Delhi.

ty could not resolve the issue of allowing MPs from the State to contest the Assembly election.

Earlier in the day, All India Congress Committee (AICC) president Mallikarjun Kharge made it clear that sitting MPs will not

contest in the Assembly election.

Mr. Sudhakaran, who has been camping in Delhi, remained unwavering in his demand, citing a promise by the party leadership when he relinquished the KPCC presidency. Senior leaders, meanwhile, said other MPs keen on contesting the Assembly polls were silently rooting for Mr. Sudhakaran.

When reports last came in around 10 p.m. on Wednesday, the central election committee had reconvened for a second time in the day to thrash out the issues in Kerala.

Mr. Sudhakaran had reportedly settled his MPs’ dues, fuelling speculation

that he might contest on his own against the Congress’ official candidate in Kannur.

K. Rajmohan Unnithan, MP, said “diluting” the AICC’s decision to keep the MPs out of the fray would not augur well for the party’s image. “An exemption would whet the appetite of other MPs to enter the fray, opening the door for disension,” he said in Delhi.

CWC member Shashi Tharoor, MP, seemed to disagree. “Two or three MPs from Kerala have evinced interest in competing in the Assembly elections. They are the party’s strong assets. There is nothing amiss in giving them a chance,” he said.

Webinar on biotech careers in food and nutrition sector to be held on March 22

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu and VIT Chennai will organise a webinar titled “Biotech Careers: Food and Nutrition” on March 22 at 11:30 a.m.

The webinar is held as part of their initiative, “Biotechnology: Role in Industry 5.0-Sustainable Future Pathways”, which aims to focus on biotechnology’s increasing influence in various sectors, including agriculture,



food, healthcare, and research-driven innovation.

The webinar will have insights on the role of biotechnology in the food and nutrition sector, which in-

cludes advancements in food processing, sustainability, nutrition science and safety.

The webinar will feature G. Jayaraman, professor and dean, School of Bio Sciences and Technology, VIT Chennai; Chakkaravarthi Saravanan, associate professor, National Institute of Food Technology Entrepreneurship and Management, and VIT Alumni; R. Balaguru, technical director, V.K. Palappa Nadar Poultry Farms Priv-

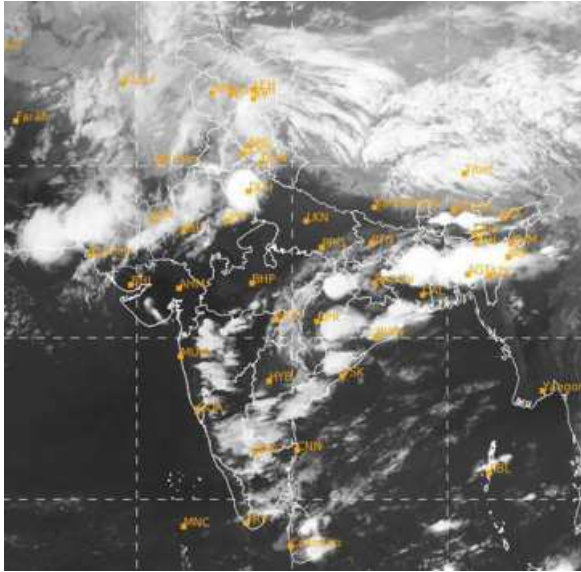
ate Limited and VIT Alumni; and Anand K. Jodi, general manager and plant head, ICML Medak, ITC Limited. It will be moderated by journalist Soma Basu.

Researchers, students and aspiring professionals will get a detailed understanding of career opportunities and emerging trends. To register, please visit <https://newsth.live/thvtfne> or scan the QR code.



WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Thursday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand. Thunderstorm with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Punjab, Delhi, Assam, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, Jharkhand, Odisha, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		32.5	23.0	Kozhikode	13	33.6	22.2
Ahmedabad		36.3	23.2	Kurnool		35.5	21.6
Aizawl		31.0	14.5	Lucknow		34.9	18.6
Allahabad		37.6	18.8	Madurai	0.2	34.4	24.1
Bengaluru		32.3	20.5	Mangaluru		33.1	24.3
Bhopal		35.4	16.6	Mumbai		31.3	21.3
Bhubaneswar		34.7	23.0	Mysuru	30	33.8	16.2
Chandigarh		27.8	13.5	New Delhi		33.6	18.0
Chennai		34.2	25.2	Patna		33.9	23.0
Coimbatore	0.3	34.2	24.0	Port Blair		31.9	27.2
Dehradun		28.5	14.2	Puducherry		32.5	24.8
Gangtok	0.6	20.1	10.9	Pune		37.8	20.9
Goa		34.2	23.4	Raipur		35.5	23.5
Guwahati		30.4	19.5	Ranchi		34.2	18.5
Hubballi		32.0	21.0	Shillong	0.2	22.0	10.0
Hyderabad	4	28.4	18.5	Shimla		19.2	10.0
Imphal		26.5	14.9	Srinagar	0.2	8.4	6.7
Jaipur		33.7	21.4	Thiruvananthapuram		34.8	25.3
Kochi	5	31.6	25.8	Tiruchi		35.7	25.4
Kohima		23.0	13.7	Vijayawada		32.9	23.4
Kolkata		33.5	24.5	Visakhapatnam		32.5	25.0

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	37	86	16	110	179		In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Mandi
Bengaluru	4	17	36	127	145		Gobindgarh, Punjab
Chennai	5	5	40	29	68		recorded an overall air
Delhi	84	52	117	243	198		quality index (AQI) score
Hyderabad	2	9	75	48	66		of 285 indicating an
Kolkata	8	49	31	39	47		unhealthy level of
Lucknow	14	40	45	142	162		pollution. In contrast,
Mumbai	9	81	28	44	101		Pampore, Jammu &
Pune		46	39	122	144		Kashmir recorded a
Visakhapatnam	26	49	11	26	70		healthy AQI score of 27

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease



केन्द्रीय विद्यालय संगठन

केन्द्रीय विद्यालय संगठन (.मु), नई दिल्ली

प्रवेश सूचना 2026-27

- शैक्षणिक सत्र 2026-27 के लिए केन्द्रीय विद्यालयों में कक्षा I एवं बालवाटिका (चयनित विद्यालयों) में प्रवेश हेतु ऑनलाइन पंजीकरण दिनांक 20.03.2026 प्रातः 10:00 बजे से दिनांक 02.04.2026 तक होगा। प्रवेश संबंधित विवरण वेबसाइट <https://kvsangathan.nic.in/en/admission/> के माध्यम से प्राप्त किया जा सकता है। कक्षा I एवं बालवाटिका 1, 2 एवं 3 (जहाँ लागू हो) के लिए ऑनलाइन आवेदन करने का लिंक: <https://admission.kvs.gov.in>
- कक्षा-I में प्रवेश के लिए न्यूनतम आयु 06 वर्ष होनी अनिवार्य है। सभी कक्षाओं के लिए आयु की गणना 31.03.2026 के अनुसार होगी। कक्षाओं में सीटों का आरक्षण के निर्देशों-दिशा के प्रवेश .सं.वि.2026-27 के अनुसार किया जाएगा।
- बालवाटिका-1, 2 एवं 3 में प्रवेश हेतु आयु क्रमशः 3 से 4 वर्ष, 4 से 5 वर्ष और 5 से 6 वर्ष होगी, जो 31.03.2026 के अनुसार होगी।
- बालवाटिका-2 व 3 (जहाँ ऑनलाइन माध्यम से आवेदन नहीं होना है), कक्षा II एवं उससे ऊपर (कक्षा XI को छोड़कर) की कक्षाओं में, प्रवेश के लिए पंजीकरण दिनांक ,स्थान रिकू होने पर ही 02.04.2026 प्रातः 10 00:बजे से दिनांक 08.04.2026 सायं 4:00 बजे तक ऑफलाइन मोड (offline mode) द्वारा किया जा सकेगा। विधिवत भरे हुए फॉर्म को संबंधित के०वि० में प्राचार्य के कार्यालय में जमा करवाना होगा।
- बालवाटिका-2 व 3 (जहाँ ऑनलाइन माध्यम से आवेदन नहीं होना है), कक्षा-II और उससे ऊपर के लिए प्रवेश और पंजीकरण प्रपत्रों के बारे में सभी जानकारी विद्यालयों की वेबसाइट पर उपलब्ध की जाएगी तथा प्रवेश हेतु पंजीकरण प्रवेश -2026-27 की अनुसूची के अनुसार किया जाएगा।
- यदि संवीक्षा के अंतर्गत आवेदन पत्र में कोई गलत/ भ्रामक जानकारी पायी जाती है तो के.वि. में प्रवेश प्रक्रिया के दौरान/पश्चात् प्रवेश निरस्त कर दिया जाएगा।
- प्राचार्यप्रवेश प्रभारी द्वारा विद्यालय में बुलाए जाने पर, निर्धारित समय अंतराल में ही संपर्क करें।

Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan (HQs), New Delhi

Admission Notice: 2026-27

- Online Registration for Admission in Class-I and Balvatika (in selected KVs) in Kendriya Vidyalayas for the Academic Year 2026-27 will commence at 10:00 am on 20.03.2026 and will close on 02.04.2026. The details of admission are available on website <https://kvsangathan.nic.in/en/admission/>. Link to apply online for Class 1 and Balvatika 1, 2 and 3 (wherever applicable): <https://admission.kvs.gov.in>
- Minimum age for admission in Class-I will be 6 years. Reckoning of age for all Classes shall be as on 31.03.2026. Reservation of seats will be as per KVS Admission Guidelines 2026-27.
- Age for Balvatika-1, 2 & 3 will be 3 to 4 years, 4 to 5 years and 5 to 6 years respectively as on 31.03.2026.
- Registration for fresh admissions, in Balvatika-2 & 3 (where online admissions are not taking place), Class II and above (except class XI), will start from 02.04.2026 at 10:00 am to 08.04.2026 up to 04:00 pm, if vacancies exist, in offline mode only. The duly filled up form needs to be submitted to the office of the Principal in the respective KV.
- All information regarding Admission & Registration forms for Balvatika-2 & 3 (where online admissions are not taking place), Class-II and above, if vacancies exist, will be available on the Vidyalaya Websites and registrations can be done as per the Schedule for Admission 2026-27.
- Admission will not be granted, if wrong and misleading information in the application form is found at the time of scrutiny by the KV.
- Contact Principal/Admission In-charge, only when called, in the given time slot.



THE HINDU GROUP

Training future leaders with 21st century communication skills





STEP LIVE Junior

NEXT GEN SOFT SKILLS

An interactive English learning course for kids from classes 4-7.

Limited Seats!

Coach your kids with 10 LIVE classes on present day aspects of communication.

- Speaking** Strategies to improve public speaking skills with focus on aspects such as persuasion, expression of emotions, etc.
- Writing** Best practices to improve writing structure and introduction to using tools like PowerPoint
- Listening** Engaging exercises and activities to actively develop listening skills
- Practice** Practical tips and guidance to continue developing communication skills

Scan the QR code





No end to suffering

India must enlist more support against Pakistan's bombing of Afghanistan

As the U.S.-Israel war against Iran rages, India's western frontiers have flared up, intensified by recent clashes between Pakistan and Afghanistan forces on the Durand Line. On Tuesday, Pakistani airstrikes tragically killed at least 400 Afghans at a drug treatment and rehabilitation centre. Pakistan, which has accused the Taliban administration of harbouring the Tehreek e Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and supporting its terror attacks on Pakistan, denied Afghanistan's accusations, claiming that its strikes had only targeted "military installations". Despite the denial, it is clear from visuals that the Omid Rehabilitation Facility in Kabul was destroyed. In an extremely strong statement, India condemned what it called Pakistan's "cowardly" targeting of a hospital, rejecting its denial as a cover-up for a "massacre", and called for an international inquiry. The Pakistan-Afghanistan conflict, which has been simmering for over a year, escalated in February when the Pakistan Air Force struck Taliban bases in Kabul, Kandahar, and Paktia in what it called Operation Ghazab Lil Haq (Righteous Fury). Tensions have also risen after TTP attacks killed 11 soldiers and a child in Bajaur and 32 people in an Islamabad mosque following a suicide bombing. Pakistan has also been angered by closer India-Afghanistan ties and New Delhi's hosting of Taliban ministers, accusing the Taliban of turning Afghanistan into an "Indian colony" – a turnaround from its support in 2021, for the Taliban's rise to power in Kabul. Apart from its continued tensions and hatred of India, and now Afghanistan, Pakistan possibly benefits from the global focus on the U.S.-Israel war with Iran. The U.S.'s actions here and its statement expressing support for Pakistan's "right to defend itself against Taliban attacks", has also imbued Pakistan's generals with a sense of impunity to strike targets in Afghanistan at will.

New Delhi could be permitted some sense of 'payback' as Islamabad's fight against cross-border terrorism from Afghanistan mirrors India's problems with Pakistan. The constraints on Pakistan's military in a two-front situation with India and Afghanistan, compounded by a transnational war on the third front, may also be the source of some relief for India. With no dialogue with Pakistan, and the limited dialogue with a Taliban regime it deals with but does not formally recognise, India's diplomatic role in the conflict is limited. However, it must enlist other SCO members that have been concerned over the outbreak of an "open war" between Pakistan and Afghanistan, to intervene. The region is already suffering from trade, energy and travel restrictions as a result of the West Asia war, to risk more volatility and loss of lives, particularly in Afghanistan, where the vulnerable, especially women, have suffered the most.

Fire and more fire

India must treat hospital fire safety as an issue of criminal accountability

Cuttack is not an anomaly. It is the latest entry in a ledger of preventable deaths in Indian hospital ICUs. In 2016, 22 people died in a fire at a private hospital ICU in Bhubaneswar, which did not have the mandatory fire safety clearance. Following this tragedy, fire safety audits were made compulsory for such facilities. Last year, the Odisha government allocated about ₹320 crore for fire safety improvement across hospitals in the State. But this did not prevent the fire at the government SCB Medical College and Hospital, Cuttack, apparently caused by a short circuit in the ICU of the trauma care unit. Some reports suggest the fire may have started in a ventilator, which was later found heavily charred. The accident, which occurred in the early hours of Monday, claimed 12 of the 23 ICU patients. Although the hospital had a firefighting unit, its personnel arrived after more than 30 minutes, reportedly because staff did not alert them early. Additionally, the fire hydrants could not be operated by staff. Nevertheless, water is not the right medium to fight electric fires, which are best extinguished using carbon dioxide, a method that requires trained personnel. Last October, six patients were killed in an ICU fire in Rajasthan. In 2024, newborns died in an ICU fire in Jhansi, Uttar Pradesh. Two similar accidents were reported in Maharashtra in 2021. An audit in Jhansi revealed hazards including exposed wiring, inadequate earthing and electrical circuits not matching power load requirements – the last being a leading cause of electrical fires in India.

ICUs have intrinsic safety risks, as their oxygen-rich environment can turn even a spark into an inferno. ICUs are also packed with electrical equipment, and the personnel are not always well trained in their safe handling. State-of-the-art medical equipment comes with advanced electronics and variable frequency drives that generate what are called "harmonic currents". These currents flow within circuits and typically have no safety devices such as circuit breakers. Harmonics create silent, persistent overheating and insulation degradation and are a severe fire hazard. Today's electrical practice lays down that every time a new ventilator is wheeled into an ICU, the wiring, protection and load capacity must be re-evaluated. Older facilities need an electrical upgrade before cutting edge equipment can be installed. As patients in ICUs are often sedated, intubated, and connected to machines, staff must be trained to ensure their safe evacuation. Until India treats hospital fire safety as a matter of criminal accountability rather than bureaucratic paperwork, the fires will keep burning and the bodies will keep mounting.

NCERT book ban, a chapter on judicial transparency

Max Boot, former Features Editor of *The Wall Street Journal*, authored the seminal study on the United States judiciary, 'Out of Order: Arrogance, Corruption, and Incompetence on the Bench' (1998). Robert H. Bork, former Solicitor General of the United States, wrote the foreword to it with a striking conclusion – "Our Courts are behaving badly and the public, to the degree it can be brought to understand that, will exert force for reform, a reform that must be structural as well as intellectual and moral."

He observed that the book's subtitle sums up a system in distress. The book underscores the critical role that the media and citizens must play while dealing with the judicial institution in a democracy.

In February this year, the Supreme Court of India, faulting what it felt as selective reference to corruption within the judiciary, directed "a complete blanket ban" on a Class eight social science textbook published by the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT). The three-judge Bench, presided over by the Chief Justice of India, further alluded to "an underlying agenda to undermine the institutional authority and demean the dignity of the judiciary".

The Court subsequently ordered that the persons responsible for preparing the passages should be 'disassociated' from future projects by governments and public universities. The Court thus instantly punished them, without due process or hearing. The prohibition by the Court is problematic as it sends critical signals about the shape of India's democracy today.

What appears to have annoyed the Bench were the passages in the book on judicial delay and corruption in judiciary. As per the news report cited by the Court, the textbook has data on the approximate number of pending cases in Indian courts. It refers to the Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct, which prescribe values for judicial life. It also discusses the in-house procedures evolved by the Supreme Court and the constitutional mechanism for the removal of errant judges.

An undermining of freedom

By itself, a book ban is the most egregious form of censorship. Such a move directly impacts the right to freedom of speech under Article 19, a solemn promise in the Constitution. This right could be restricted only by a law made by the



Kaleeswaram Raj

is a lawyer in the Supreme Court of India



Thulasi K. Raj

is a lawyer in the Supreme Court of India

The top court's ban on an NCERT textbook exposes gaps in judicial accountability and public trust

state on grounds expressly provided under Article 19(2), such as "the sovereignty and integrity of India, the security of the state, friendly relations with foreign states, public order, decency or morality, or in relation to contempt of court, defamation, or incitement to an offence". There is no law made by the state to justify the ban on the book in question. Judicial orders or judgments do not come under the realm of 'law' made by the state, as understood in the context of Article 19 (*Nareesh Shridhar Mirajkar vs State of Maharashtra*, 1966).

For an act to amount to contempt of court, there must be material that scandalises the authority of the court or prejudices or interferes with judicial proceedings or the administration of justice, as defined under Section 2(c) of the Contempt of Courts Act, 1971. Whether mere references to corruption in the judiciary and case backlogs meet this high threshold for criminal contempt was a question that, unfortunately, did not form part of the Court's deliberations. What was also not examined was whether the statements were too general in nature to suggest any malicious intent to scandalise the Court.

Further, and importantly, going by the scheme of judicial review, courts must put to constitutional scrutiny the law passed by Parliament often violating fundamental rights. When the courts take on the task of book banning, citizens are left without remedy, as constitutional courts are the last resort to safeguard fundamental rights.

Global efforts

In advanced democracies, the credibility of the court is a matter of concern, primarily for the court itself. Transparency International has conducted a number of surveys that show that there is a prevailing notion about judicial corruption. Judiciaries across the world have made efforts to address this problem. In Kenya, the reforms led by Chief Justice Willy Mutunga, between 2011 and 2013, are an illustrative example. During this period, institutions such as judicial ombudspersons, court users' committees, and performance management committees were established.

By 2013, public trust in Kenya in the judiciary had risen to 61%, compared to 27% in 2009. The reforms continued even thereafter. This happened only by acknowledging the issues and trying to address them, rather than suppressing critical voices.

The opportunity in Cameroon to rebalance the WTO

Today, trade is no longer just about economics. It is increasingly used as a geopolitical tool. Tariffs are imposed as pressure tactics, and economic dependence is sometimes used strategically. In this context, the World Trade Organization (WTO)'s Ministerial Conference (MC14), to be held in Yaoundé, Cameroon, Africa (March 26-29, 2026), comes at an important moment. The real issue is not whether the WTO needs reform, but whether it can adapt fast enough to stay relevant in a world moving toward more transactional and power-based trade relations.

WTO in turmoil

The WTO is facing its biggest crisis since its founding in 1995. Its dispute settlement system is still effectively paralysed because the Appellate Body appointments have been stalled for years. This weakens trust in the system, since rules matter only when they can be enforced. At the same time, WTO negotiations have struggled to keep pace with major shifts in global trade. Digital commerce is growing rapidly and now forms a large part of cross-border economic activity. Yet, WTO rules have not evolved at the same pace.

Decision-making has also become slow and difficult. With 166 members at very different levels of development, consensus is hard to reach and cumbersome. As a result, many negotiations produce limited outcomes and long-pending issues remain unresolved.

Meanwhile, geopolitical tensions and the growing use of tariffs as political tools have distorted markets. However, these problems should not be mistaken for irrelevance. Most global trade still operates under WTO rules. If enforceable multilateral rules weaken, global trade would become unpredictable and unstable. Smaller and poorer countries would suffer the most, because they rely on common rules to protect themselves from pressure by stronger economies.

The WTO's challenges are also part of a wider shift in the global order. The Munich Security



Rajeev Ranjan Chaturvedy

is an Associate Professor, heading the School of International Relations and Peace Studies, and founding coordinator of the Centre for Bay of Bengal Studies, Nalanda University, Rajgir, Bihar



Anushka Padmanabh Antrolikar

is a postgraduate scholar at Nalanda University, Rajgir, Bihar

The World Trade Organization's Ministerial Conference must ensure that trade is governed by rules rather than coercion

Report 2026 describes this as a move toward "wrecking-ball politics", where countries prefer disruption and short-term deals instead of gradual institutional reform. In trade, this is visible in the rise of unilateral tariffs, economic coercion and bilateral deals that bypass multilateral commitments. If this continues, rule-based trade could be replaced by ad hoc arrangements shaped mainly by power rather than shared principles.

Global production has changed

Against this backdrop, the MC14 offers a chance not just to fix technical problems but to also restore balance between predictability and fairness. The original balance of rights and obligations in the WTO no longer reflects today's reality. Emerging economies now export advanced and technology-intensive products, climate-related trade measures are expanding, and digital networks are reshaping how global production works.

Rules designed for a late 20th century trading system cannot fully govern a 21st century one.

Reform must start with restoring credibility to enforcement. Without a functioning dispute settlement system, commitments lose their value. Members need to rebuild a binding, trusted mechanism rather than relying mainly on temporary alternatives that lack universal acceptance. A robust dispute-resolution system helps remove politics from conflicts and keeps confidence in multilateral rules.

At the same time, predictability must go hand in hand with fairness. Long-standing disputes over agricultural subsidies, market distortions and unequal openness need transparent solutions. Many developing countries argue that while WTO rules ensure the rule of law, they do not always deliver the rule of justice. In other words, rules may be legally correct but still produce outcomes that feel unequal or developmentally unfair.

Reform should, therefore, improve transparency on subsidies, create credible

In India, the courts including the top court have acknowledged the menace of delay and corruption. Judges have repeatedly warned about the 'bad apples' within the system. The very existence of the in-house Procedure indicates the possibility that a minuscule number of judges may breach their oath.

In *K. Veeraswami vs Union Of India And Others* (1991), the Court categorically held that judges of the High Courts and the Supreme Court fall within the definition of "public servant" for the purposes of prosecution under the Prevention of Corruption Act, while also cautioning against the potential for misuse of this provision by the executive. The Court also said: "We consider that the society's demand for honesty in a judge is exacting and absolute. The standards of judicial behaviour, both on and off the Bench, are normally extremely high. For a Judge to deviate from such standards of honesty and impartiality is to betray the trust reposed on him. No excuse or no legal relativity can condone such betrayal. From the standpoint of justice, the size of the bribe or scope of corruption cannot be the scale for measuring a judge's dishonour. A single dishonest judge not only dishonours himself and disgraces his office but jeopardises the integrity of the entire judicial system."

The need for introspection

Therefore, the need to eradicate corruption and delay is also in the best interest of the judiciary. In the interim order directing the book ban, the Court also pointed out that the "book also chooses not to delve into any of the transformative initiatives and measures pioneered by this Court towards overhauling legal aid mechanisms and streamlining the ease of access to justice". Not addressing all counterarguments might render an opinion potentially incomplete. Yet, that is no reason for banning the view expressed. If the exercise of free speech is required to follow a particular form, the right itself becomes illusory. During judicial deliberations, nobody pointed out that the judiciary, like other organs of the state, must be open to dissent and reform.

The first step in fighting systemic problems such as corruption – whether in the executive or the judiciary – is acknowledging it. After all, it is imperative to curb all kinds of corruption and that civil society is educated about the institutional challenges. A court that continuously reforms itself is the bedrock of any democracy.

responses to distortive practices, and revisit special and differential treatment so that it remains meaningful in today's economic conditions.

Institutional adaptability is also important. The WTO's structures were designed for a smaller and less complex membership, which contributes to today's deadlock. Some countries are moving ahead in smaller groups on issues such as e-commerce, investment facilitation, and services. These efforts can help progress, but they must remain transparent, inclusive and connected to the wider WTO framework. Flexibility should help the system move forward, not divide it. If such initiatives remain open to all members and eventually become part of common WTO rules, they can support reform instead of fragmentation.

Ultimately, WTO reform is not only technical but also normative. The Munich Security Report warns that a world shaped mainly by transactional deals would favour the powerful and leave weaker countries vulnerable.

The choice is clear

The WTO's value lies in preventing exactly this outcome by ensuring that trade is governed by rules rather than coercion. In an era of strategic competition, rules do not weaken sovereignty; they protect countries from economic domination.

The choice before the MC14 is crystal clear. Members can undertake serious reform, preserving the WTO's stabilising core while updating its rules, procedures and developmental balance, or allow the system to drift further into fragmentation. Achieving reform will require political will and shared responsibility.

Rebalancing the WTO is ultimately about securing a workable framework for cooperation in a world where economic interdependence is still unavoidable. If the MC14 seizes this opportunity, it can show that meaningful reform remains the most credible path to sustaining global trade governance.

AI and finance industry

Artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming the finance industry, offering both significant opportunities and notable challenges. AI enhances operational efficiency by improving decision-making, credit scoring, and portfolio management, while also strengthening risk management through faster, more accurate fraud detection. Customer experiences are increasingly personalised with chatbots and AI-driven insights. However, automation may

displace repetitive jobs even as it creates new high-skilled roles, and ethical concerns along with cyber risks require robust governance. Financial institutions must balance innovation with responsibility, invest in workforce reskilling, and prioritise transparency to ensure sustainable growth and equitable opportunities.

Senthilkumar Govindarajalu, New Jersey, U.S.

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

India’s future demographic challenges

A new report by the International Institute of Migration and Development and the Population Foundation of India titled ‘Unravelling India’s Demographic Future: Population Projections for States and Union Territories, 2021-2051’, underscores the demographic risks that are beginning to surface nationwide. India’s population is projected to increase from 1,355.8 million in 2021 to 1,590.1 million in 2051, with an average annual increase of 0.5%, suggesting a prolonged period of slower population expansion. These figures fall below earlier estimates, strengthening the case that India is unlikely to face the threat of population explosion that once dominated political and academic debates. These projections point to a turning point, where India is poised to move beyond a youth-led, fast-expanding population into an era of a more urban, steadily ageing, and balanced demographic structure.

A problem for schools
The projections point out that the pre-primary school-going population (0-4 years) is expected to dwindle from 113.5 million in 2021 to 8.6 million by the middle of this century. Since most regions in the country are now close to universal primary school enrolments, the demand for new schooling facilities could ease out, especially in the government sector. A sustained drop in fertility could leave the country with an escalating number of ‘uneconomic schools’ (schools with lesser enrolment rates that cannot justify their economic costs), raising the threat of teachers losing their jobs, a trend that the State of Kerala has seen play out for more than three decades.

Evidence from different parts of the country suggests that declining fertility rates have already started influencing schooling requirements, with classrooms adjusting to smaller cohorts. Data from the Unified District



S. Irudaya Rajan
Chair, International Institute of Migration and Development, Kerala



J. Retnakumar
Senior Research Fellow, International Institute of Migration and Development, Kerala

The growing elderly population is set to exert increasing pressure on healthcare and social security, thereby putting a strain on the state’s finances

Information System for Education and the Ministry of Education highlights a significant reduction in the number of government schools over the last decade, with schools dropping from 11.07 lakh in 2014-15 to 10.18 lakh in 2023-24, amounting to a reduction of close to 90,000 schools across the country. This decline has been accompanied by a sharp increase in private schools; their numbers grew from 2.88 lakh to 3.31 lakh over the same period, an increase of 43,000 schools.

While falling birth rates have led to a reduction in enrolments and closure of government schools, smaller families and improved capacity to afford education have propelled the demand for private schools. Many parents choose private schools in the hope of giving their wards the education they never had in life, nudged by social pressure and a common perception that government schools generally fall short on quality compared to private schools.

Greying population
As the demographic dividend largely depends on the working age population (15-59), a relatively higher proportion of this specific group can lead to faster economic growth, a dynamic evident in the development phases of several countries, including China, Japan, and South Korea. India has one of the world’s largest workforces, rising from 833.8 million (65.2%) in 2021 to a projected peak level of 1,009.0 million (65.5%) in 2041, before declining to 998.1 million (62.8%) by 2051. There is an impending concern that the demographic dividend window will close after 2041, highlighting the urgency of leveraging it before its contribution to economic growth starts to diminish. Nevertheless, close to six out of every 10 persons in the country are expected to be part of the workforce by 2051, which is an encouraging sign. However, India’s population is ageing. In 2021, India’s elderly

population (60+) stood at 130.5 million or 9.62% of the population. By 2051, this number is projected to touch 325.3 million (20.5%), highlighting that there will be a profound increment in the ageing population. The median age, a measure that splits the population evenly by age, is projected to climb from 28 years in 2021 to 40 by 2051, signalling India’s shift towards a more advanced stage of demographic transition. The growing elderly population is set to exert increasing pressure on healthcare and social security, thereby putting a strain on the state’s finances.

Policy signals
The declining child population is expected to offer a better teacher-pupil ratio and expand infrastructural facilities in schools. Further, declining birth rates reduce demand for maternity care, allowing the healthcare system to rationalise the use of resources and offer better quality care. Though fertility levels have been falling, continued investments are required for family planning and to prevent unintended pregnancies, as well as reduce infertility and ensure the reproductive rights of women. India needs to overhaul its education and skill development system to cope with modern-day challenges. It should also equip the younger generation to seize new opportunities before our demographic leverage disappears in the coming decades. The decline in the working-age population can be offset by bringing in more women to formal work (gender dividend) and by expanding access to better-quality employment. With the rapid growth of the elderly population, India’s financial and healthcare systems, especially geriatric care, must be redesigned to support the growing needs of elderly citizens. At the same time, this creates a strong potential for a thriving silver economy, and could help in unlocking a second demographic dividend in the future.

A plausible three-cornered fight

The third player in Tamil Nadu electoral politics has always been a disruptor

STATE OF PLAY

T. Ramakrishnan
ramakrishnan.t@thehindu.co.in



For the past one week or so, the political arena in Tamil Nadu has been dominated by reports of frenzied attempts to bring the fledgling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), headed by popular film star Vijay, under the fold of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Talks of the TVK negotiating its entry into the NDA was laid to rest by party functionaries earlier this week. Leaders of the AIADMK and its ally, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which was said to be keen on roping in the TVK, also denied that talks were held in this regard. Political circles were abuzz with the speculation that the BJP was trying to bring the TVK into the NDA fold, as soon as the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Congress signed an electoral pact on March 4, after days of uncertainty and hard bargaining.

When the talks between the Dravidian major and the national party were on, there was a lot of noise about the possibility of the Congress ditching its long-standing ally in favour of the TVK. Once this issue became irrelevant, media attention turned to the theory of TVK joining hands with the AIADMK and the BJP. In October 2024, Mr. Vijay said that he was open to not only an alliance, but also to the idea of sharing power.

Luring in the TVK
What fuelled speculation was the perception that given the arithmetic strength of the DMK-led Secular Progressive

Alliance (SPA), the NDA would not be able to defeat the SPA. This was based on the fact that in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, the SPA secured 47% of votes polled while the AIADMK and its ally, the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) netted 23% and the BJP-led NDA, 18.24% (now, the DMDK is a constituent of the SPA). As per an estimate, even after giving allowance for the political developments for and against the SPA in the last two years, the NDA still requires a minimum of five percentage points to put up a tough fight. Only the TVK can bridge this gap in vote share.

Of course, another reason cited for the alliance is that all the three major parties – the AIADMK, the BJP and the TVK – have the same goal of defeating the DMK. After all, at one stage, the first two had openly courted the TVK. About 10 days after the tragic stampede at the TVK leader’s rally in Karur in September 2025, which claimed 41 lives, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, during his visit to Namakkal, remarked that “a beginning” had been made for the alliance. He made this observation in reference to a few people holding up the TVK flag at the meeting.

Even as Mr. Vijay began holding interviews, on March 10, with aspirants for the Assembly election at the party headquarters in Panaiyur on the outskirts of Chennai, me-

dia circles were abuzz about alliance talks. Mr. Vijay’s scheduled visit to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) office in New Delhi on March 15 was linked to the much-speculated deal. Even though the party’s high-level administrative committee chief coordinator K.A. Sengottaiyan on March 12 clarified that his organisation would go to the polls alone, political circles were agog with speculation that a majority of the TVK district secretaries supported joining the NDA. This was reportedly conveyed during a virtual interaction with the party general secretary ‘Bussy’ N. Anand. As of today, TVK’s office-bearers have not denied that any such interaction took place, even though they rebut reports of holding negotiations for the alliance.

‘Fancy offers’
Addressing a public meeting on March 17, TVK general secretary Aadhav Arjuna, regarded as one of the key functionaries of the party, claimed that “fancy offers” – 90 assembly seats and the post of Chief Minister for one half of the Assembly term of five years – had been made to his party but Mr. Vijay was “very firm” in rejecting them, and that the party would stand by religious minorities. But, he did not state who made the offer. On Wednesday evening, the TVK chief reiterated at an iftar event that his party would not compromise on secularism and social justice. Even though there is still time for more alliance drama, a three-cornered fight looks imminent. As in the past, the third force is bound to be a disruptor. It is to be seen which formation – the SPA or the NDA – benefits from the solo performance of Mr. Vijay and his colleagues.

Children have borne the brunt of Israel-U.S. aggression

Israel accounted for about 41% of all external attacks that ended with a child fatality, while the U.S. accounted for 21% of such attacks

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Nivedha M.

On the morning of February 28, as hundreds of young girls were attending their classes in Minab’s Shajareh Tayyebah school, the building was struck by a missile.

Residents and rescuers, who rushed to help seeing black smoke rising from the school, found blood stained backpacks, severed arms, and dead children buried under piles of rubble.

The school was likely struck by one of the U.S.’s Tomahawk cruise missiles, claimed to be one of the most precise guided weapons in the world. The school was one of the casualties in the targeted attacks by the U.S. on Iran, in conjunction with Israel.

Later reports confirmed that around 168 children, mostly aged between seven and 12, were killed in the attack. The school was located adjacent to a naval compound operated by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC).

Though U.S. President Donald Trump initially suggested that Iran itself – despite not having Tomahawk missiles – may have been responsible for these attacks, media reports and the U.S.’s preliminary military investigations suggest the attack was a result of the U.S.’s use of outdated targeting data.

The Pentagon elevated its probe into the matter last week. A UN inquiry is also underway to investigate the fatal strike. Amnesty International, this week, said that the strike points to a failure by the U.S. forces to take feasible precautions to avoid civilian harm.

A war on children

However, the girls in Minab weren’t the only ones who paid the price of the ongoing war. More children are estimated to have been killed in the daily strikes launched by the U.S. and Israel on

Iran in separate instances.

Less than two thousand kilometres away, in Lebanon, more than a hundred children have been killed by Israel’s campaign since March 2. Reports indicate that Israeli airstrikes have completely wiped out generations of families in the country in less than two weeks. The death toll due to the ongoing conflict in Lebanon is reported to be rising faster than any other war that the country had previously endured.

What happened in Minab and what is unfolding in Lebanon aren’t isolated instances. Data points to a more troubling pattern – the U.S. and Israel together accounted for about 62% of “external attacks” that ended with a child casualty since 1996. External attacks refer to acts of aggression or military involvement by an actor on foreign soil.

The *Hindu* analysed events of external attacks that were recorded by the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project. While over 66,000 events of external attacks have been lethal (ending with any fatalities), around 4% of such reported attacks have ended up with at least one child fatality.

Incidences of attacks were used as a proxy, as data for child fatalities under external attacks were not separately maintained. These events offer a reliable snapshot of the extent of attacks against children during conflict. However, fatalities in individual events may be significantly higher. The data only pertains to confirmed events of deaths, and therefore cases of missing children or unreported events of deaths are not included in the analysis.

A further look at the 4% reveals that close to 2,500 reported cases of external attacks have ended with a child fatality between 1996 and 2026.

A country-wise analysis of these events show that Israel accounted for about 41% of all external attacks that ended with a child fatality (**Chart 1**). That is, about one in

every nine lethal attacks (11%) launched by Israel since 1996 has killed at least one child.

No other country has recorded such events as high as Israel. The figures reflect the violent escalations in Gaza and West Bank since October 7, 2023 including instances when children were killed while receiving aid; via airstrikes; and in refugee camps. Close to 20,000 children have been killed in Gaza between October 7, 2023 and August, 2025. Infants alone accounted for 10% of these figures. This is despite the fact that Israel, globally, only accounted for 14% of lethal external attacks. (**Chart 2**)

Meanwhile, Russia alone accounted for 55% of lethal external attacks since 1996. Less than 2% of them have been reported to kill a child.

As for the U.S. which ranked second, in terms of external attacks carried out by countries that resulted in a child fatality, data shows that roughly around 7% of its lethal external attacks had resulted in a child casualty.

Grave violation

The United Nations Security Council identifies killing and maiming of children as one of the six grave violations against children in times of war. Children in these conflict zones might also be exposed to other atrocities such as recruitment by armed groups, sexual violence, abduction and denial of humanitarian access.

Days after the Minab school strike, the UN Committee on the Rights of the Child said in a statement that the strikes on civilian infrastructure, including schools and hospitals, serve as a stark reminder that children are among the most vulnerable in armed conflicts. It added that children must never be treated as collateral damage. However, with intensifying attacks and more buildings falling to rubble, children are at an increasing risk of becoming exactly that.

Nivedha M. is internng with the Hindu Data Team



A heavy toll: Graves are being prepared for the victims following a strike on a school in Minab, Iran, on March 2. REUTERS

Caught in the crossfire

The data for the charts were sourced from the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project. Data for 2026 pertains only till March 6

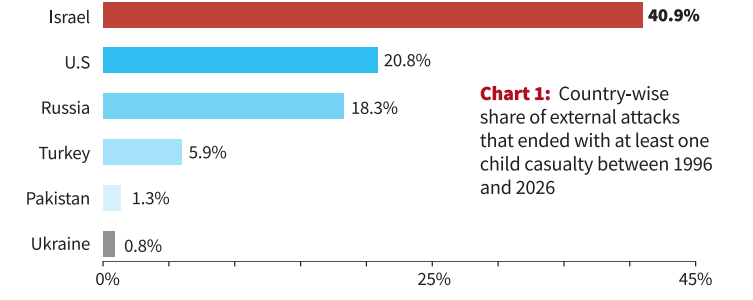
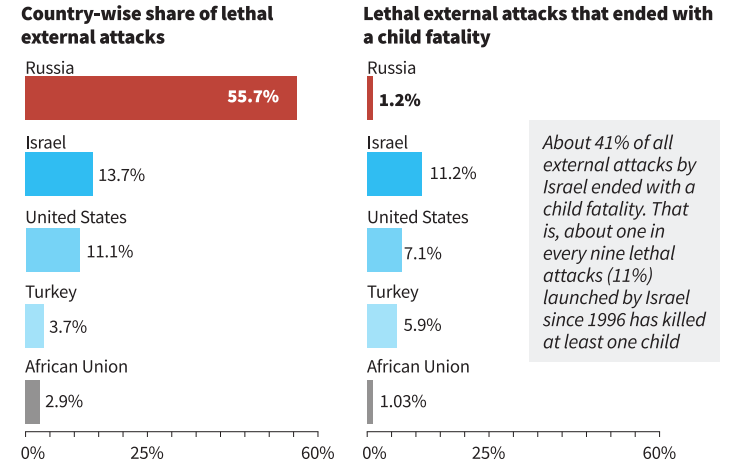


Chart 1: Country-wise share of external attacks that ended with at least one child casualty between 1996 and 2026



Note: Figures in the charts above may not add up to 100 as they only include the top countries in terms of share

■ Attacks attributed to the African Union refer to the African Union Mission in Somalia and the African Union Transition Mission in Somalia

■ Attacks attributed to the U.S. include those under the ‘Global Coalition Against Daesh,’ as it was a U.S.-led coalition

The data only pertains to confirmed events of deaths, therefore cases of missing children or unreported events of deaths are not included in the analysis

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The *Hindu*.

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 19, 1976

French author’s reply to critics

Madras, March 18: Mr. Dominique Lapierre, co-author of “Freedom at Midnight”, claimed to-day that the controversial book was objective history and “a hymn of love for India” and did not distort the facts in any way.

“Four years of hard work and research have gone into the book and to dismiss it as fiction is most unjust”, he said at a press conference.

Turning to the controversial part which maintains that Nehru and Patel, unable to handle the partition riots, secretly requested Mountbatten to take charge of the situation, Mr. Lapierre said this account though never published before was accurate. A memorandum at the U.K. Government archives, which had been dictated contemporaneously by Mountbatten, recorded the conversation among the three. This version was also corroborated by the private papers of Mr. V.P. Menon.

He said that far from denigrating Nehru, the book only brought out his greatness and political courage in having an Englishman as head of State after independence. “One cannot conceive of Ben Bella, for instance, asking De Gaulle to become head of State in independent Algeria though it might have solved many of their difficulties”, he remarked.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 19, 1926

“Doodle” annual

We extend our congratulations to our humorous contemporary ‘Doodle’ on entering its sixth year of publication, which it does with its current number. For these five years this weekly journal has been providing mirth and relaxation for the public through its amusing cartoons, humorous stories, pungent – but never offensive – skits and burlesques mainly dealing with Indian social life, farces, sharp pieces of witticism etc. The first number of its sixth volume which is now before us is decidedly an improvement on its predecessors in more than one direction. It is slightly bulkier than hitherto and its cartoons on local politics are as delightful as they are to the point. Its “curry and chutney” are indeed well-dressed and the “pickings” too are a choice selection. We have no doubt this pioneer venture in a branch of journalism which is yet to come into its own in India will receive the support and encouragement it deserves.

CM
YK

ASSEMBLY POLLS

EC continues transfers in West Bengal

▼ The Election Commission (EC) continued to transfer officers of West Bengal on Wednesday. Ten District Magistrates (DM), one Municipal Commissioner, and five Deputy Inspector-Generals of Police (DIG) were transferred. The newly appointed officers met the Chief

Electoral Officer (CEO) of West Bengal, Manoj Kumar Agarwal, to review the poll preparedness in the State. A total of 39 officers have been transferred in the State since the election was announced on Sunday, including top-ranking police officers. The government has been asked to not assign any election-related duties to any of the transferred officers. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee had criticised the EC for “favouring the BJP” in making these transfers.



Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Kumar Agarwal met the newly appointed officers.

Rebellion in Venugopal's home turf

▼ A district Congress leader on Wednesday revolted in AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal's home turf, Alappuzha, over the party's candidates' list for the coming Assembly polls and announced that he would contest as an Independent in the key Kuttanad constituency in Kerala.

Mr. Venugopal represents the Alappuzha constituency in the Lok Sabha. DCC vice-president Saji Joseph on Wednesday resigned from the party and announced he would contest as an Independent candidate from the Kuttanad Assembly constituency. The leadership's decision to give the Kuttanad seat to the UDF ally, Kerala Congress (Joseph) faction, against the reported request of the local Congress leaders and workers, irked Mr. Joseph and his supporters. PTI



●● I think that by pitting Suwendu Adhikari against Mamata Banerjee in Bhabanipur, we have managed to trap the Trinamool supremo in one corner
DILIP GHOSH
Senior BJP leader

Ex-Trinamool leader's party to contest 182 seats

▼ Expelled Trinamool Congress leader Humayun Kabir on Wednesday announced the first list of 15 candidates for his Aam Janata Unnayan Party, declaring that the outfit would contest 182 seats in the Assembly election in West Bengal. It will field a Muslim candidate against Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee. PTI



●● In three terms, our vote share and representation have expanded because people have seen the benefits of these schemes
JAIPRAKASH MAJUMDAR
Senior Trinamool leader



In a lighter vein: IUML State president Sayyid Sadiq Ali Shihab Thangal with P.K. Kunhalikutty in Malappuram, Kerala, on Tuesday. SAKERE HUSSAIN

IUML bets on youth, ushers in generational shift in Kerala

Abdul Latheef Naha
MALAPPURAM

The Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leadership, led by State president Sayyid Sadiq Ali Shihab Thangal, has sought to quell internal criticism by ushering in a generational shift through its candidate list for the April 9 Kerala Assembly election.

The announcement of candidates on Tuesday surprised many, particularly critics within the party, as it reflected a conscious move to infuse young blood into its legislative ranks. For months, younger members had been quietly demanding greater representation, and the list of the 25 candidates appears to address those concerns.

The party has introduced 11 new faces, including six young leaders, two women, and one non-Muslim candidate. The move was widely welcomed by party workers, especially the youth.

Notable picks

Among the notable picks are Fathima Tahilia for Perambra, T.P. Ashraf Ali for Kondotty, P.K. Firoz for Koduvally, V.K. Faisal Babu for Kozhikode South, and P.K. Navas for Tanur. All of them represent the party's younger leadership.

The other woman candidate, Jayanthi Rajan, a non-Muslim woman, will contest from Koothuparamba in the Kannur district. Ms. Rajan, a former panchayat member of the IUML, also expressed happiness about her candidature.

“We have considered all sections and held extensive consultations before finalising the list,” said Mr. Thangal.

The leadership further signalled its intent by fielding K.M. Shaji in Vengara, a stronghold vacated by national general secretary P.K. Kunhalikutty, who has shifted to Malappuram.

However, the transition has not been without friction. Party State secretary Abdurahman Randathani stirred a controversy by criticising the selection of P.M.A. Sameer in Tirurangadi. But, Mr. Sameer's candidature has found support among sections of the party's youth.

While the Women's League, the party's women's wing, has expressed dissatisfaction over the selection of the two women candidates, political analyst G. Gopakumar described the IUML leadership's decision as a “very welcoming and progressive move”.

The IUML had earlier hinted at a generational transition during the local body election by limiting repeat candidates. The appointment of younger leaders like A.P. Smiji to key local posts had also signalled a shift towards inclusivity and renewal.

Many within the party view this as its most significant generational change since 1991, when leaders like Mr. Kunhalikutty and E.T. Mohammed Basheer rose to prominence at relatively young ages. Today, in contrast, the party's legislative leadership has aged considerably.

Nine sitting MLAs

Nine sitting MLAs have been retained, while several senior leaders have been dropped to make way for new entrants, underscoring the leadership's attempt to balance continuity with change.

Overall, the candidate list marks a decisive shift in the IUML's approach: one that seeks to rejuvenate the party while managing internal dissent.

(With PTI inputs)

‘Double engine’ faces test in Puducherry as NDA’s stability pitch meets Opposition attack

The AINRC-BJP front has been cultivating a perception of stable governance; it is also banking on welfare delivery; the INDIA bloc's attack will likely revolve around the ‘promises-versus-delivery’ gap of the Rangasamy govt., rising unemployment, perceived neglect of the U.T. in the Union Budget

IN FOCUS

M. Dinesh Varma
PUDUCHERRY

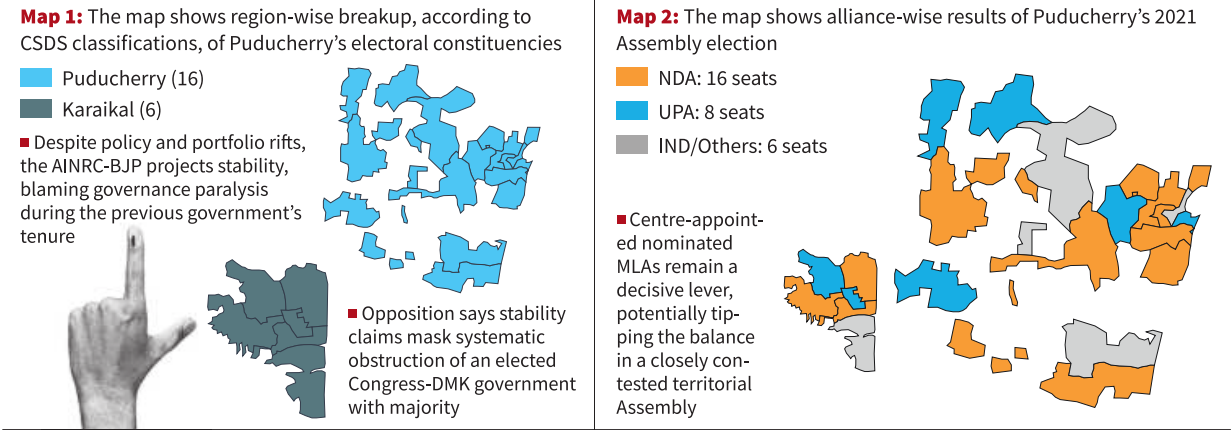
Puducherry, which saw its first-ever AINRC-BJP government installed in 2021, gets its earliest opportunity to deliver a verdict on five years of the much-touted “double-engine” governance model when the Union Territory goes to the polls on April 9.

The All India N.R. Congress (AINRC), led by four-time Chief Minister N. Rangasamy, leads the headcount in the current 15th Legislative Assembly with 10 MLAs, while its ally, the BJP, has six. The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the principal Opposition party, has six MLAs and the Congress two, while there are six Independents.

The run-up to this election can turn out to be a tame affair in comparison to the tumultuous phase that preceded the previous Assembly election. There was a long-drawn stand-off between former Chief Minister V. Narayanasamy and then Lieutenant-Governor Kiran Bedi over governance rights. His dharana in front of the Raj Nivas over Ms. Bedi's “authoritarian and obstructionist” ways, and election-eve defections, eventually precipitated the collapse of the Congress government on February 22, 2021, barely weeks before completing its term.

Battleground Puducherry

The April 9 election in the Union Territory pits incumbent NDA touting stability against a divided Opposition, with alliances, welfare politics, and Centre-appointed nominees shaping the race



The AINRC-BJP front, in spite of signs of a rift over policy matters and portfolio allocation, has been cultivating a perception of stable governance – Mr. Rangasamy has especially attacked the confrontationalist style of his predecessor, which he believes precipitated a governance crisis and development stalemate.

The counterview in the Opposition camp is that such a claim obscures the cause and only projects the effects of systematically impeding the functioning of an elected government that had begun its 2016-21 term with a comfortable majority of 15 Congress members and two DMK MLAs.

The bottom line of the 2021 verdict was that the Congress, which strutted about the political landscape of Puducherry as a

dominant force for decades, failed to make a convincing case before the electorate and ended up with just two seats.

Seat-sharing talks

While the party may have recovered its standing when its candidate V. Vaithilingam trounced sitting BJP Minister A. Namasivayam by 1.36 lakh votes in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the ghosts of its 2021 debacle continue to haunt the party, especially in preserving its leadership role in the INDIA bloc. That the DMK, having emerged as the principal Opposition, appears keen to reset the power equation has not eased matters.

DMK Puducherry convenor and Leader of the Opposition R. Siva has repeatedly pitched the idea for ushering in a “Dravidian model” government

in the Union Territory, but what has further ruffled feathers in the Congress camp was when DMK MP and Puducherry in-charge S. Jagathrakshakan chaired a preliminary round of seat-sharing discussions separately with each of the allies in the INDIA bloc – the CPI(M), the CPI, and the VCK. This power struggle is one of the reasons why seat-sharing talks between the Congress and the DMK have hardly been a smooth sailing.

In contrast, the NDA has been able to evolve a broad agreement among allies. Last week, the coalition announced a seat-sharing formula modelled on the 2021 pattern, with the AINRC contesting 16 seats and the BJP and others splitting the remaining 14 seats.

Nirmal Kumar Surana, BJP in-charge for Puducherry, who was here for

talks with Mr. Rangasamy along with Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, had also hinted at expanding the alliance, with the Latchiya Jananayaga Katchi likely to enter the NDA fold. A point of interest surrounds the number of seats allotted to the AIADMK, which had contested five seats in 2021 but drew a blank.

While the Naam Tamilar Katchi, which finished ahead of the AIADMK in the 2024 Lok Sabha results, will field candidates in 28 Assembly constituencies, it remains to be seen if Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam makes good its founder-president Vijay's announcement to contest in Puducherry in December 2025.

As the rival fronts hit the campaign trail, the NDA will try to smother the anti-incumbency factor by projecting the stability and

welfare orientation of its term.

Course correction

In recent months, the Rangasamy government has, in an apparent course correction, reopened ration shops that were shut after the Direct Benefit Transfer system of cash in lieu of rice was imposed by the Centre during the Congress term, and restored rice distribution through the Public Distribution System. The government has also been filling vacancies and rolling out a slew of welfare measures, such as financial assistance to women heads of BPL families and a hike in pension for old and destitute persons.

The NDA will also look to extract political capital from the unveiling of projects worth about ₹2,700 crore by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in March.

The INDIA bloc's attack will likely revolve around the “promises-versus-delivery gap” of the Rangasamy government, rising unemployment, perceived neglect of the UT in the Union Budget, deterioration in law and order, drug menace, exposure of a sensational temple land grab case, and a fake drug manufacturing racket with nation-wide ramifications. The Opposition has also charged that Mr. Rangasamy's fourth stint as Chief Minister has been marked by an acquiescence to the BJP, a failure to stand up for federal rights, and a hollow commitment to the statehood cause.

Protests erupt in Bengal over Trinamool poll picks; axed MLAs mulling retirement

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

A day after the Trinamool Congress announced candidates for the 2026 West Bengal Assembly polls, discontent surfaced among several party leaders who were denied ticket.

Protests erupted at Amtanga in the North 24 Parganas on Wednesday after three-time MLA from Amtanga, Rafiqur Rahman, was denied ticket. His supporters blocked roads and burnt tyres while Mr. Rahman urged the party leadership to reconsider their decision. The Trinamool has replaced the MLA with Peerzada Kasem Siddiqui, who hails from a family of religious leaders.

Protest erupted at Jibantala in Canning Purba Assembly seat in South 24 Parganas after the party decided to field MLA Saokat Molla from the Bhargar Assembly seat in the same district. Mr. Molla, an influential leader, wants to contest from Canning Pur-



Losing temper: Protests were held at Jibantala over the Trinamool's ticket distribution on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ba. His supporters blocked roads by burning tyres at Jibantala.

Express anguish

In the list of candidates announced on Tuesday, the Trinamool dropped 74 legislators and shifted 15 MLAs to different constituencies. Several MLAs expressed anguish and said they would go into political retirement.

Senior MLA Asit Majumdar has been denied ticket from Chinsurah, and the party named Debangshu Bhattacharya as the candidate from the seat instead.

Mr. Majumdar, said he had reached out to Trinamool general secretary Abhishek Banerjee over the development, and added that he was considering political retirement.

Among the MLAs who have been dropped is Tajmul Hossain from Harischandrapur constituency in Malda district. Mr. Hosain, who is a Minister in the outgoing Cabinet, said he had been “betrayed” by the party. Protests were also reported from Islampur, where senior MLA Abdul Karim Chowdhury was dropped.

Day after quitting Congress in Assam, senior leader Pradyut Bordoloi joins BJP

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

The Assam Congress is wary of the possible impact of losing one of its three MPs from the State to the BJP, a month after its former State president Bhupen Kumar Borah jumped ship.

Pradyut Bordoloi, who represented the grand old party from Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency, joined the BJP on Wednesday. Mr. Bordoloi was the chairman of the Congress's Manifesto Committee.

Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, chairperson of the party's Screening Committee for candidates, said the MP's resignation was unfortunate. “I think he was upset over one ticket allocation. I wish we had a chance for a conversation,” she said. However, senior Congress leaders indicated Mr. Bordoloi had been planning to don saffron for a long time.

Jitendra Singh, AICC secretary in charge of Assam, pointed out that the candidate Mr. Bordoloi objected



Jumping ship: Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma, left, and BJP Assam president Dilip Saikia welcome MP Pradyut Bordoloi. PTI

to did not figure in the two lists released so far. “This means we were considering Pradyut Bordoloi's recommendations. I have spoken to him on this a couple of times, and he knew my stand. One thing is clear: As politicians, we should realise that we are elected by our voters to represent them with dignity and sincerity and not to sell their votes as a negotiator,” Mr. Singh said on X.

In a letter to Mr. Singh a few days ago, Mr. Bordoloi threatened to quit if the party re-nominated MLA Asif Mohammad Nazar

from the Laharighat constituency. The seat is part of the Muslim-majority Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency, which Mr. Bordoloi represents.

Congress leaders in Assam have put up a brave front, insisting that a series of resignations was a boon in disguise. They accused the defectors of having been “BJP agents”. A section within the party, however, said the resignations of Mr. Borah and Mr. Bordoloi in quick succession could affect the party's morale as it heads to the polls.

INBRIEF



Ethyl chloroformate imports from China: India opens probe

India on Tuesday opened an anti-dumping investigation into ethyl chloroformate imports from China after a domestic producer alleged the chemical used in pharmaceutical and agrochemical manufacturing was being sold at unfairly low prices. The Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR), under the federal trade ministry, said it initiated the probe following an application by Paushak that alleged that imports from China had caused “material injury” to domestic producers. The Chinese embassy in New Delhi did not immediately respond to a request for comment. In December, India imposed a three-year import tariff of 11% to 13% on some steel imports, in an effort to curb cheap Chinese products. Ethyl chloroformate is an organic chemical intermediate widely used in pharmaceutical and agrochemical manufacturing. REUTERS

Five working groups proposed on health insurance

Five strategic working groups co-chaired by leaders from the healthcare and insurance industries will be set up on various issues concerning health insurance and formalise a roadmap for systemic reforms. The aim is to improve insurance penetration, transparency and the overall patient experience by addressing long-standing operational gaps and coordination issues between insurers and healthcare providers. The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) announced this following a high-level industry interaction on March 17 in which Chairman Ajay Seth participated. Most of the working groups are scheduled to begin work in April, with durations ranging from 2-4 months. The findings and recommendations from these groups will serve as a reference model for future industry standards and regulatory frameworks, the insurance regulator said in a release.

Solar ingot plan to take off June '28, boost local output

Jacob P Koshy
NEW DELHI

In a bid to boost local output of solar ingots and wafers - constituents of solar cells fitted on solar panels - the Ministry for New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) said from June 2028, only ingots and wafers made in India would be eligible for domestic projects. It did this by announcing the Approved List of Module Manufacturers (ALMM) List-III for Ingots and Wafers – a list of firms making the components – on Wednesday. As of date, such an ALMM list exists for manufacturers of solar cells and modules. The ALMM is a compulsory registration regime by the



India mulls adding 280 GW of solar capacity by 2030.

MNRE, first issued in 2019.

In Govt.-funded plans Only ALMM-listed modules can be used in government-funded, open-access and net-metering solar projects such as PM Surya Ghar and PM Kusum scheme and Solar Energy

Plastic goods prices to rise 60% as war impacts polymer

Prices of polymer, derived from crude oil and natural gas, have risen by 50-60% creating margin pressure; plastic manufacturers managing with stocks procured prior to W. Asia war outbreak

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Plastic product prices are expected to rise by 50-60% from April if the West Asia crisis continues to impact supply of key raw material, mainly crude oil, industry officials said. They said the prices of polymer, derived from crude oil and natural gas, have risen by 50-60% in the last few days, creating margin pressure. Plastic manufacturers said they are yet to fully pass on the additional financial burden to customers as they are managing with the inventory procured well before the war broke out. But stocks are fast depleting, they said. “Manufacturers are procuring raw material based on the order on a day-to-day basis and pricing the supplies based on the raw material price,” said Sunil Shah, president, All India Plastics Manufacturers' Association (AIPMA).



Burden of cost: The price of a small water bottle, which is ₹2 now, is expected to go up to more than ₹3. R. VENGADESH

“The cost of a small water bottle is about ₹2 and if prices rise it would cost more than ₹3. It all depends on the bottled water brand to either absorb that cost or pass it on to buyers. Similarly, the price of a 20-litre plastic water bottle, which is about ₹110 now, can go up sharply,” industry officials said. Confirming that polymer prices had gone up over the last few weeks, Arvind M Mehta, chairman, All India Plastics Manufacturers

Association said despite the price hike, exports could continue. “For exports, we are positive because our international competitors will have the same raw material price,” Mr. Mehta said. The increasing cost of packaging materials has also threatened to inflate the price of food items in the retail market. Rice producers in Kangayam, a rice mill hub in Tamil Nadu, said the bags they used to pack 26 kg of rice used to cost ₹23 a

piece. Now, it is ₹29 a piece. “We have local suppliers who get the packing material in rolls and stitch it for us according to our requirement. There is a delay in getting those bags too. We buy another type of bag from Gujarat. The prices of both these varieties of bags have shot up,” said Palaniswamy, president of the Kangayam Rice Mill Association. The oil mill owners in Kangayam said they pack edible oil in plastic bottles or pouches. A bottle that used to cost ₹10 is now sold for ₹15. The oil mills have told their bulk buyers that they may increase the end product prices if this continues for a month. In Tirupur, leading brands and all hosiery manufacturers for the domestic market have announced that hosiery products will be priced ₹7 more apiece as the cost of inputs have shot up. (With inputs from Soundariya Preetha in Coimbatore)

Analysts forecast cut in oil firms' earnings

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Elevated crude premiums, currency depreciation and mounting freight costs will hit the earnings of oil marketing companies (OMCs) in fiscal 2027, according to analyst reports. “We are reducing our

FY 2027E earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (EBITDA) by 45-47% for BPCL and HPCL and 28% for IOCL. We also cut FY 2028E EBITDA by 3-8%. Further firming up in oil prices could push OMCs into losses in FY2027E,” Kotak Institutional Equities said in its re-

port, recommending clients to sell the stocks. “With integrated margin under pressure and share of refining margin in overall integrated margin increasing, companies with higher earnings sensitivity to marketing margins will be the most negatively impacted. For every INR 1/ltr

decrease in marketing margin, IOCL/BPCL/HPCL's FY27 EPS reduces by 21/20/24%,” HDFC Securities said in a note. “Given that IOCL has a lower marketing mix in the overall volume, it should fare better compared with peers like BPCL and HPCL in the near term,” it added.

Producers make a pitch for increasing use of ethanol

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

The Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) has written to the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), urging the Government for a fast-tracked and calibrated roadmap for ethanol blending beyond E20.

‘Initiate a pilot’ The Grain Ethanol Manufacturers Association recently appealed to the Centre to initiate a study or pilot programme to examine technical feasibility, safety standards and economic viability of ethanol-based cooking solutions. With the Iran war resulting in higher oil prices and



An ethanol based cook stove.

LPG shortage, they want the government to promote the use of ethanol. India now imports almost 85% of crude oil. The West Asia tensions and disruptions in global shipping routes showed vulnerabilities in global energy supply chains, ISMA said. India now has an in-

stalled distillation capacity of almost 2,000 crore litre (including both sugar- and grain-based ethanol), with sugar sector contributing about 900 crore litre. The ethanol need for achieving E20 blending is estimated at about 1,100 crore litre a year indicating only about 55% of the installed capacity will be used. “India possesses adequate local ethanol production capacity to move beyond E20, making this an opportune moment for a calibrated and forward-looking roadmap,” said Deepak Ballani, DG, ISMA. “Advancing higher ethanol blends, phased roll-out of flex-fuel vehicles will boost value retention within domestic economy.”

Cabinet okays ₹33,660-cr. BHAVYA plan for 100 industrial parks by '32

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet approved the Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA), with an allocation of ₹33,660 crore for the development of 100 ‘plug-and-play’ industrial parks across the country. The aim was to create 100 “future ready” industrial parks integrated with the PM GatiShakti to make use of the latter's multimodal connectivity and last-mile access. “These parks will set new benchmarks in industrial infrastructure, ensuring reliability, reducing in-



Manufacturing boost: KINFRA integrated industrial park in Kerala. K. K. MUSTAFAH. (FOR REPRESENTATIONAL PURPOSE ONLY)

efficiencies and enhancing productivity across sectors,” the government said. As per Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade Secretary Amardeep Singh Bhatia,

the scheme's duration would be for six years starting 2026-27. The first phase would see 50 parks being set up. The minimum land need for the parks would

be 100 acre in most cases, and 25 acre for industrial parks in hilly or North Eastern States. The maximum size is 1,000 acre. **States, pvt. sector** While the Union government will provide up to ₹1 crore per acre, the scheme is meant to involve State governments as well as the private sector. “At the heart of BHAVYA lies a strong push for deregulation and ease of doing business, with streamlined approvals, effective single-window systems, and investor-friendly reforms led by States,” the government said.

CCI gets ₹1,719 crore to pay support price

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs has approved a funding of ₹1,718.56 crore to the Cotton Corporation of India (CCI) to meet the minimum support price (MSP) needs for the cotton season 2023-24. The Government said the move is aimed at providing direct price support to cotton farmers in India. The Centre hoped this intervention would stabilise cotton prices, prevent distress sales, and ensure better returns to farmers. The MSP per quintal of medium staple cotton was ₹6,620 and ₹7,020 for long



Such interventions play a crucial role in stabilising prices.

staple cotton, in the 2023-24 season. During that season, with an estimated 114.47 lakh hectares under cultivation and production pegged at 325.22 lakh bales, this accounted for nearly 25% of global cotton output, the release noted.

Centre offers 10% additional LPG to States, UTs that fast track CGD network

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Seeking to enhance penetration of piped natural gas (PNG) among commercial entities whilst attempting to support supplies of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), which has been constrained due to tensions in West Asia, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) has written to State governments and Union Territories, offering to allocate them an additional 10% of cooking gas provided they facilitated speedy expansion of city gas distribution (CGD) networks. The Ministry also sought to provide more supplies in a tiered structure, should States meet certain ‘eligibility criteria’ for supporting the transition to piped gas. If met, the MoPNG said it would allow an additional supply of up to 4% of commercial LPG. “Through the letter, all States and UTs have been offered an additional 10% of LPG allocation provided they help in expediting expansion of the CGD network,” Joint Secretary at MoPNG Sujata Sharma told reporters.



The Centre underlined that its push for PNG is to ease the pressure on LPG.

The Centre underlined that its push for PNG is to ease the pressure on LPG. India imports 60% of its consumption requirements, of which 90% is routed through the Strait of Hormuz, which has been effectively shut. On the availability of natural gas in India, Ms. Sharma said, “We have sufficient stocks of LNG and

that is primarily one of the reasons that we are asking consumers to shift to PNG.” She said more than 1.2 lakh new PNG connections had been distributed in the past two weeks. This is inclusive of domestic, industrial and commercial users, alongside CNG stations. An additional 1% of commercial LPG would be allocated should States constitute committees for approving pending applications of CGDs and resolve their grievances. Another 2% would be allocated if CGDs are given deemed approvals. States would be able to avail yet another 3% LPG allocation if they introduced “dig and restore” scheme for CGD entities. At the daily inter-ministerial press briefing, Ms. Sharma also mentioned that 15 States have begun supplies of commercial LPG. These include Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Kerala, Manipur, Rajasthan and Uttarakhand, among others.



Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited
(A Govt. of India Enterprise & a group Company of IndianOil)

[CIN – L40101TN1965GOI005389]
Regd. Office: No.536, Anna Salai, Teyrnampet, Chennai – 600 018
Website: www.cpcl.co.in Email ID: shankarp@cpcl.co.in Phone No.: (044)24346807

NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS

**SPECIAL WINDOW FOR RE-LODGE-
MENT OF TRANSFER REQUESTS OF PHYSICAL SHARES**

Pursuant to SEBI Circular dated 30th January 2026, shareholders are informed that a special window has been re-opened only for re-lodgement of transfer deeds along with physical share certificates which were lodged prior to the deadline of 1st April 2019 and were rejected/returned/not attended to, due to deficiency in the documents/process or otherwise.

This facility of re-lodgement will be available to the eligible physical shareholders till **4th February 2027**. Shareholders are requested to re-submit their transfer requests along with physical share certificates with our Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, KFin Technologies Ltd. whose details are given below:

KFin Technologies Ltd.
Unit: Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited
Selenium Tower B, Plot number 31 & 32
Financial District, Nanakramguda
Hyderabad - 500032
Toll Free No – 1800 309 4001
E-mail Address: einward.ris@kfinitech.com

For Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited
Sd/-
P. Shankar
Company Secretary

Place : Chennai
Date : 17th March 2026

RAJASTHAN HIGH COURT BENCH AT JAIPUR
SB/DB Civil writ petition No./2026

CASE TITLE :
Any Effected Person
Vs.
State of Raj. & Ors.
Application Rule 159 of Rajasthan High Court
Rules for entering in to CAVEAT

May it please your lordships :
Your Lordship's humble applicant wants to enter into caveat under Rule 159 of the Rajasthan High Court Rules and let nothing be done till the applicants are heard in the matter. The particulars of the Appeal / Revision which is likely to be filed are given below:-

The following persons may file the appeal:-
Any Effected Person.
That the appeal is likely to be filed against:-
1- The Principal Secretary, Local Self Government, Govt. Secretariat, Jaipur (Raj.).
2. The Director cum Special Secretary, Local self Government, Govt. Secretariat, Jaipur (Raj.).
3- The Chief Engineer (SBM), Rajasthan Urban Drinking Water Sewerage and Infrastructure Corporation Ltd., Jaipur (Raj.).
4- The Financial Advisor, Directorate of Local Bodies, Jaipur (Raj.).

That the judgement against which the Revision / Appeal / writ is to be filled is from the order passed by the **Director cum Special Secretary, Local Self Government, Government Secretariat, Jaipur (Raj.)** vide order dated **06-03-2026**, bearing no. **F.55(JPA/CE/FSTP/2025-26/3727 Dated : 06-03-2026**.
That Vakalatnama on behalf of **Shri Rajesh Kumar Meena, Superintending Engineer, FSTP Cell, Director of Local Bodies Department, Jaipur (Raj.)** is submitted herewith.
It is, therefore, humbly prayed that nothing be done in the case till the applicants are heard.

HUMBLE PETITIONER
THROUGH HIS COUNSELS
(Gurcharan Singh Gill)
ADDITIONAL ADVOCATE GENERAL

JAIPUR
DATED:
DIPR/C/5650/2026

TEHRAN

Murderers must pay for killing Iran’s Larijani: Mojtaba Khamenei



Iran’s new Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei said on Wednesday that the killers of security chief Ali Larijani “will have to pay for it”. “Every drop of spilled blood comes at a price, and the criminal murderers of these martyrs will soon have to pay it,” Mr. Khamenei said, in a message published on his official Telegram channel. AFP

KABUL

Mass burials expected for victims of Kabul drug rehab centre strike



Afghans readied on Wednesday to bury their dead from this week’s Pakistani air strike on a Kabul drug treatment centre, as an international NGO confirmed that hundreds were killed and wounded. Interior Ministry spokesperson Abdul Mateen Qani confirmed a mass funeral would be held later Wednesday. AFP

JAKARTA

Indonesia arrests four military officers ‘involved in acid attack’



Indonesian military authorities said on Wednesday that they have arrested four officers allegedly involved in an acid attack on an activist known for his opposition to the expanded role of military in civilian life. Andrie Yunus suffered burns to 20% of his face and body from acid thrown by assailants from a motorcycle. REUTERS

LONDON

Scottish Parliament rejects Bill to let terminally ill people end lives



Scottish lawmakers rejected a Bill on Tuesday that would have legalised assisted dying. The proposed law, if passed by Parliament and approved by the British government, would have allowed Scots with a terminal illness and a life expectancy of six months or less to seek help to end their life. AFP

Israel conducts waves of attacks on Beirut; to strike river crossings

Israel targets densely populated areas like Bashoura, Basta, and Zuqaq al-Blat in strikes; Lebanese authorities report at least 12 deaths and 41 injuries, including Hezbollah’s *Al Manar* TV director; 912 killed and over a million displaced in Lebanon

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Israel repeatedly struck central Beirut on Wednesday, with Lebanese authorities reporting a death toll of at least 12 including a director for Hezbollah’s *Al Manar* TV channel, and said it would strike river crossings in south Lebanon. Lebanon was drawn into the West Asia war on March 2 when militant group Hezbollah launched rockets into Israel to avenge the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Israel responded with intense strikes on multiple



Major hit: Flame rises from a residential building following an Israeli air strike in central Beirut, Lebanon, on Wednesday. AP

regions around the country and by launching ground operations in the south. It has also hit central Beirut several times, with and without warning. On Wednesday, three densely populated neighbourhoods in the heart of Beirut were hit. In Bashoura, a whole building collapsed into a mound of

rubble after being struck. A map shared by the Israeli military indicated the targeted building had already been hit last week, also after an evacuation warning. Lebanese authorities on Tuesday said Israeli strikes have killed at least 912 people since March 2, while more than a million people have registered as displaced. Lebanon’s official *National News Agency* (NNA) earlier said a strike had hit an apartment in the central Zuqaq al-Blat neighbourhood, a densely populated area close to the government’s headquarters and several embassies. Hezbollah’s *Al Manar* TV said Mohammad Sherri, the director of its political programmes, had been killed along with his wife in one of the strikes in Zuqaq al-Blat. Lebanon’s Health Ministry reported a preliminary toll for strikes on both areas of 12 dead and 41 wounded, adding that efforts were under way to identify those killed. The Israeli military on Wednesday said it planned to strike bridges and crossings over the Litani River. “To prevent the transfer of reinforcements and weapons, the (Israeli army) intends to attack crossings on the Litani River.”

Cuba vows ‘unbreakable resistance’

Agence France-Presse
HAVANA

Cuba’s leader on Tuesday said the U.S. would face “unbreakable resistance” if it tries to take over the island nation. U.S. President Donald Trump said on Monday he would “take” Cuba, adding: “We’ll be doing something with Cuba very soon.” “Faced with the worst-case scenario, Cuba has one guarantee: any external aggressor will encounter an unbreakable resistance,” Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel wrote in a statement on X.

Festive exodus



Ferry frenzy: Thousands of travellers scramble and jostle each other to board ferries at the Sadarghat Launch Terminal, joining the massive annual exodus to celebrate Id ul-Fitr in their hometowns, in Dhaka, Bangladesh, on Wednesday. AP

As fire and fury hit Trump’s MAGA tent, Vance walks the tightrope for 2028

NEWS ANALYSIS

Varghese K. George

The fire and fury that is consuming the MAGA (Make America Great Again) fraternity that had rallied behind Donald J. Trump’s anti-war rhetoric for a decade touched the administration on Tuesday when Joe Kent, a long-term acolyte, resigned as the director of the National Counterterrorism Centre. “Iran posed no imminent threat to our nation, and it is clear that we started this war due to pressure from Israel and its powerful American lobby,” Mr. Kent, who served in the U.S. Army for 20 years and later in the CIA, wrote in his resignation letter. Laura Loomer, an influential cheerleader of the war who has Mr. Trump’s ear took to social media speculating that Tulsi Gabbard, Director of National Intelligence and a strong opponent of wars, could be the next to resign. The new war launched by Mr. Trump and Benjamin Netanyahu is triggering a wide range of realignment of personal loyalties and political positions across both parties, but a role reversal within the Republican Party is remarkable. Three key figures who are now the main mouthpieces of Mr. Trump’s new war – Senators Lindsey Graham and Ted Cruz and Secretary of State Marco Rubio – were opponents of Mr. Trump in his primary contest in 2015. **Difficult line** Mr. Trump had clashed with all three on policy issues, particularly on West Asian wars, and hurled insults at all three. While they now rally Republicans behind Mr. Trump – polling shows above 80% of

the party’s supporters backing the war – MAGA natives such as Mr. Kent could find it increasingly difficult to remain in the Trump tent. Marjorie Taylor Greene resigned from the House of Representatives on January 5, 2026, nearly two months before the war began, while Vice-President J.D. Vance and Ms. Gabbard are walking a difficult line. Both have stopped short of supporting the war but reiterated their trust in Mr. Trump’s judgement and capacity. Their position is as follows: that it is not in America’s interest for Iran to have a nuclear weapon, and Mr. Trump knows what he is doing. This framing allows them to continue in the administration while not endorsing the war completely, and holding Mr. Trump responsible for the consequences while praising his leadership.



Core group: Donald Trump, J.D. Vance and Marco Rubio take part in a meeting at the White House in Washington DC. REUTERS

Mr. Vance, standing next to Mr. Trump in the Oval Office on March 16, said the President had been consistent “going back to 2015...that Iran should not have a nuclear weapon. And I agree with him.” He added, “...we have a smart President whereas in the past, we’ve had dumb Presidents and I trust President Trump to get the job done... and to make sure that the mistakes of the past are not repeated.” On March 13, he did not deny the reporting that he had expressed reservations – which were publicly articulated too – about attacking Iran. Asked what his advice to Mr. Trump was, Mr. Vance said, “I’m not going to show up here and in front of God and everybody else tell you exactly what I said in that classified room – partly because I don’t want to go to prison, and partly because I think it’s important for the President of the United States to be able to talk to those advisers without those advisers running their mouth to the American media.” The stakes are high for Mr. Vance, who is 41, and the frontrunner for the Republican nomination for President in 2028. Mr. Trump has publicly acknowledged that Mr. Vance had a different view. “He was, I would say, philosophically a little bit different than me. I think he was maybe less enthusiastic about going, but he was quite enthusiastic... We get along very well on this.” Mr. Trump has also been suggesting that Mr. Vance and Mr. Rubio are both potential candidates in 2028, though the latter has so far maintained that he has no plans to challenge the Vice-President. Mr. Trump

wants to be the kingmaker in the Republican Party, and his role after the presidency will be contingent upon a contest for the nomination. **‘MAGA is Trump’** Mr. Trump has countered criticism from within his camp on two lines. One, critics do not understand MAGA, and this war fits well within the mandate that he sought in three elections. “MAGA is saving our country. MAGA is making our country great again. MAGA is America First,” he said in one interview. “MAGA wants to see our country thrive and be safe. And MAGA loves what I’m doing – every aspect of it.” Secondly, he has repeated his long-held claim that MAGA is a movement that follows him in whatever he says and decides. “I think that MAGA is Trump,” he said, dismissing criticism

that the war against Iran has betrayed the trust of his voters. He is largely right on this count. For all their scepticism of wars and global entanglement, three surveys put MAGA Republican support for the strikes at between 85 and 90% – significantly stronger than Republicans generally, and Americans generally. Since Mr. Trump manages to hold the majority of the MAGA camp within his spell, Mr. Vance has little option other than his current course. Even those who are not in the administration, such as commentator Tucker Carlson and Ms. Greene, have stopped short of personally criticising Mr. Trump, suggesting instead that he is being misled. “It’s time to reorganise. It’s already beginning. The mission, not the man,” Ms. Greene posted this week. At the moment, it is hope against force.

du Plessis backs Allen and Seifert to open for Knight Riders in IPL



Skipper Rahane should bat in the top-order for KKR, feels Balaji



Rajasthan Royals unveils its jersey for the upcoming season



Buttler keen to continue England career despite 'poor' T20 WC



Capitals need to deliver at optimum capacity to fulfil their elusive dream

Delhi Capitals



**Finalist
2020**



Tristan Stubbs

M	W
266	122

Kohli has a long stint as RCB begins training

Senegal stripped of AFCON title, Morocco declared champion

CM
Y
K

M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Schmeichel fears shoulder injury could end career

Kasper Schmeichel has revealed a major shoulder injury could end his career, saying, "I'm going to need two surgeries now to fix my shoulder. It's a bit of a body blow. I've torn the bicep, torn the rotator cuff, dislocated the shoulder, torn the labrum – everything's kind of gone."

Thomas and Uber Cup: Indian teams clubbed with China

The Indian men's and women's badminton teams, seeded eighth, have been clubbed in Group A alongside defending champion and top seed China in the Thomas and Uber Cup championships to be held in Horsens, Denmark, from April 24 to May 3.

LIVE TELECAST

Squash: Indian Open, FanCode, 12 p.m.
IFL: Sony Sports Ten 1, 5 & LIV, 4 & 6.30 p.m.
ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & FanCode, 7.30 p.m.
Europa League: Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 11.15 p.m. & 1.30 a.m. (Friday)

'Dhakshineswar can adapt to pro circuit'

TENNIS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Former India No. 1 tennis player Somdev Devvarman backed the fast-rising Dhakshineswar Suresh to quickly adapt to life on the professional circuit.

Dhakshineswar, who is representing the Wake Forest University in the US collegiate system, single-handedly guided India past the Netherlands in the recent Davis Cup Qualifiers first-round tie in Bengaluru. The 25-year-old is set to turn pro in a few months.

"Dhakshineswar is an unbelievable player. His rise has not been a surprise for people who have known him since he was a kid," Somdev said on the sidelines of the TNGF Premier League 2026 fourth round here on Wednesday. "He has put in quite a shift over the last 18 months to improve by

leaps and bounds. It is exciting because he is going to turn pro in May. There is going to be a different kind of pressure and competition week in week out. But we now know that he has the goods to do it," Somdev said of Dhakshineswar, who is ranked 474 on the ATP chart.

While Dhakshineswar has been punching well above his weight at the highest level, India No. 1 Sumit Nagal looks a shadow of the player he was a couple of years ago.

Somdev stressed that World No. 278 Nagal should become "healthy" to climb the ladder.

"The season gets tougher when you play while being unhealthy. Nagal has been unhealthy for a large part of the last six to eight months.

"Firstly, he has to get back on track. If he is healthy, he can play some great tennis," said Somdev, who mentors the 28-year-old.

AROUND THE CITY

Easy for AM Jain

AM Jain scripted an eight-wicket win over MVIT (Puducherry) in a Pool-A match of the 12th Pavit Singh Nayar Memorial T20 All-India inter-collegiate cricket tournament here on Wednesday.

In another Pool-A match, Guru Nanak beat KSR (Thiruchengode) by 35 runs, while in Pool-B Pachaiyappa's got the better of Erode side Kongu Arts & Science by 42 runs. Also in Pool-B, Pillai College of Mumbai defeated SMVEC (Puducherry) by five wickets in a low-scoring encounter.

The scores: Pool-A: MVIT (Puducherry) 61 in 18.2 overs (V. Sathyanarayanan 4/4, S. Baranidharan 3/8) lost to A.M. Jain 65/2 in 5.4 overs. Guru Nanak 205/3 in 20 overs (L.R. Nawin 85, S.R. Athish 68 n.o.) bt KSR (Thiruchengode) 170/9 in 20 overs (A.S. Ananda Kumar 46, P. Saravanan 57, D. Alfred Jacob 3/20).

Pool-B: Pachaiyappa's 187/6 in 20 overs (E. Bharathiraja 30, S. Aryan 37, M.R. Tejas Ram 33, K.

Yogeswaran 3/27) bt Kongu Arts & Science, Erode 145 in 18.2 overs (M. Manoj Rajan 32, S. Venkatesh 32, M. Subash Chandra Bose 3/22, E. Bharathiraja. 3/29). SMVEC (Puducherry) 64 in 12 overs (Harsh Singh 3/4) lost to Pillai College (Mumbai) 65/5 in 7.5 overs.

Pool-C: Guru Nanak 'B' 120/9 in 20 overs (S. Sachin Sredev 60, Arjun Nair 3/24) lost to RKM Vivekananda 121/5 in 16.5 overs (Abhinav Kannan 33, P. Nirmal Kumar 38). Gobi Arts & Science 93 in 19 overs (Navin 38, Manikandan 3/7) lost to KPR College, Coimbatore 99/6 in 13.1 overs.

Pool-D: Sri Ramakrishna CAS (Coimbatore) 158/7 in 20 overs (R. Kishore 46, Hari K. Pandya 47, Siddarth Prakash 3/25, R.S. Ambrish 3/22) lost to Loyola 159/7 in 19.3 overs (M. Vishal 49, R.S. Ambrish 37, Hari K. Pandya 3/24). CKT College (Mumbai) 112 in 17.2 overs (Saurabh Monkal 45, Ritvik Mandumula 4/33) lost to TKR (Hyderabad) 113/2 in 10.2 overs (P. Aryan Raj 37, Aryan Krishna 30).

Chess camp

The Madras School of Chess will hold a high-performance chess camp, curated by Grandmasters Vishnu

Prasanna and Akash Ganesan, with International Master V. Saravanan as guest faculty at W365, North Main Road, Anna Nagar west. The camp will be held from April 1 to 5 for players rated under 2000 and from April 6 to 10 for those under 1600. Contact 73050 53376 or 98404 03376.

Fairway Assassins finishes on top

Fairway Assassins secured the top position on the leaderboard with 390 points in the TNGF Golf Premier League, followed by The 19th Hole Smashers with 345 points, Allsec (335), and Chennai Hustlers (315). The four teams have advanced to the title round to be played on March 25 (Wednesday) at TNGF-Cosmo.

TDCA selection trials

The Tiruvallur DCA will conduct selection trials for boys u-12 (April 12), u-14 (April 13) and women (April 14) at DRBCCC

Hindu College. The trials for boys u-16 & u-19 (April 13) will be held at Magna College of Arts and Science. Application forms can be downloaded from www.thiruvallurdca.in from March 19 and must be submitted before April 5.

It is open to only players residing in the Tiruvallur revenue district, and applicants must carry proof of birth and address certificates. Physical forms can be collected from the TDCA Office, Bank of Baroda ATM upstairs (second floor), near SUGAM HOSPITALS, #212, MTH Road, Ambattur OT Bus stand from 7.30 p.m. to 9 p.m. Contact K. Sudhakaran (98404 82220) or V. Ganesan (91766 69980).

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: Pavit Singh Nayar memorial T20 all-india inter-collegiate tournament, women's semifinals, Guru Nanak College, 8.30 a.m.

Abhay aims to break into top 20 by end of the current season

SQUASH

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

India's top squash player, 27-year-old Abhay Singh, is known for his aggressive, adrenaline-driven style on court. Ranked World No. 26, he has already claimed 11 PSA Challenger titles and is now aiming to break into the top 20 by the end of the 2025-26 season.

Abhay said his "Challenger days are more or less done," and plans to focus on higher-tier events – Copper, Silver, Gold, and Platinum – though he might play the occasional Challenger. "Now it's about going into big events, winning or losing. I'm focused on bigger events," he told The Hindu during a virtual interaction on Wednesday.

While the 2026 Asian Games looms large, offering a direct route to the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics for the singles winner, Abhay is concentrating on the season. "We're just focusing on



Looking ahead: Abhay plans to focus on the bigger events. FILE PHOTO: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

the season. Six events remain, with the JSW Indian Open in Mumbai (Mar. 18 to 22) and the season-ending British Open (May 26-June 7) later. After that, my coaches James Willstrop and Harinder Singh and I will plan ahead," he said.

Despite a modest start to the season, mostly second-round exits, Abhay remained confident. "Some results have been satisfactory. Hopefully, it stays consistent, and the ranking goes

only upward," he added.

Having defeated the likes of Karim Abdul Gawad (former World No.1 and World champion) in the 2025 Qatar Classic (Platinum Grade) and Farres Dessouky (WR 16) in the 2026 Windy City Open (Platinum), Abhay will hope for such results more often than not with the World championships (May 8 to 16 in Giza, Egypt) and Asian Games (September 19 to Oct. 4 in Japan) coming up.

PSG, Real Madrid and Arsenal march into the last eight with easy wins

The title holder romps past Chelsea to claim a comprehensive 8-2 aggregate victory; the Spanish giant snuffs out City's challenge; Gunners ease past Leverkusen to keep the quadruple in sight; Sporting produces a classic comeback to end the fairytale run of Bodo/Glint

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Holder Paris Saint-Germain, record 15-time winner Real Madrid and Arsenal surged into the quarterfinals of the Champions League on Tuesday, while Sporting produced a brilliant comeback in Portugal to end Bodo/Glint's remarkable run.

PSG crushed Chelsea 3-0 in London to claim a comprehensive 8-2 aggregate victory in their last-16 tie.

Khvicha Kvaratskhelia followed his first-leg double by opening the scoring on six minutes at Stamford Bridge.

Bradley Barcola fired in a brilliant second goal from an Achraf Hakimi assist, and the home fans were streaming for the exits when substitute Senny Mayulu swept in PSG's third on the night just after



Thundering strike: Eze, centre, rockets in Arsenal's opener against Leverkusen. REUTERS

the hour.

Manchester City lost 2-1 at home to Real as it went out 5-1 on aggregate.

Real led 3-0 from the first leg in Spain and its qualification was never in

doubt after City's Bernardo Silva was sent off on 20 minutes for stopping a goal-bound Vinicius Junior shot on the line with his arm.

Vinicius converted the penalty, and Pep Guardio-

la's side had too much to do, even if Erling Haaland levelled the scores on the night before half-time with his 30th goal this season.

Real replaced Thibaut Courtois with Andriy Lu-

nin in goal at half-time, and the tie was over long before Vinicius scored again in stoppage time to seal the win on the night.

Premier League leader Arsenal's dream of a qua-

druple remains alive after it beat Bayer Leverkusen 2-0 at the Emirates Stadium for a 3-1 aggregate success.

The Gunners finished the tie off with goals either side of half-time from Ebe-rechi Eze and Declan Rice will play Sporting in the quarterfinals.

The Portuguese champion produced a superb fightback, overturning a 3-0 deficit from last week's first leg against Bodo/Glint by beating the Norwegians 5-0 after extra time in Lisbon.

The results (pre-quarterfinals, second leg): Sporting 5 (Inacio 34, Pote 61, Suarez 78-pen, Araujo 92, Nel 120+1) bt Bodo/Glint 0 (AET, Sporting wins 5-3 on aggregate). Arsenal 2 (Eze 36, Rice 63) bt Bayer Leverkusen 0 (Arsenal wins 3-1 on aggregate). Chelsea 0 lost to PSG 3 (Kvaratskhelia 6, Barcola 14, Mayulu 62) (PSG wins 8-2 on aggregate). Manchester City 1 (Haaland 41) lost to Real Madrid 2 (Vinicius Junior 22-pen, 90+3) (Real wins 5-1 on aggregate).

Quality of balls under the scanner at Natl. table tennis c'ships

Amol Karhadkar
INDORE

The quality of balls being used at the 87th senior inter-State and National table tennis championship, sponsored by Ultimate Table Tennis, has come under scrutiny, with several paddlers and coaches voicing concerns.

The tournament is using Stag Global balls, manufactured by an Indian company.

While these are ITTF-approved, they are not commonly used in World Table Tennis (WTT) events or major international competitions, nor are they consistently used across top domestic tournaments.

"These balls are lighter and get soft very early. Since these balls are not used in WTT events or at World Cups and Championships, we hardly play with them," Manav Thakkar, World No. 33 and the

highest-ranked player in the men's draw, told The Hindu on Wednesday.

The inconsistency has been evident across the circuit. While four of the five national ranking tournaments this season used Stag balls, another opted for Stiga.

The inter-institutional tournament – the second-most prestigious senior domestic event – featured DHS balls, which are also used in international competitions.

Competition manager N. Ganesan, however, defended the choice.

"We have been using only ITTF-approved balls, and it's the same case for the National championship," he said.

Former international and Arjuna awardee Soumyadeep Roy echoed the concerns, noting that the balls tend to "get soft too soon and hardly impart spin".

STATE BANK INDIA
PROJECT IMPLEMENTATION UNIT (PIU)-USDMA
Uttarakhand Disaster Preparedness & Resilience Project (U-PREPARE)
5th Floor, USDMA Building, 36, IT Park, Sahastradhara Road, DEHRADUN
Website: www.u-prepare.com; E-mail: procurement.uprepare@gmail.com
Ref. No. 274/A-25/RFB/SEOC/PIU-USDMA/U-PREPARE/2025-26 Date: 18/03/2026
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
The Government of India has received financing from the World Bank towards the cost of the Uttarakhand Preparedness and Resilient Enhancement Project (UPREPARE) and intends to apply part of the proceeds for the procurement of goods under the following package.
A complete set to bidding documents in English may be downloaded by interested eligible bidders from the website UK Tenders Portal (https://uktenders.gov.in) from 20/03/2026.
S. No. Package No. Name of Package Method of Procurement
1 IN-PIU-USDMA-511168-GO-RFB Procurement of ICT Equipment(s) for Establishment of State emergency Operation Centre (SEOC) at USDMA Building, IT Park, Dehradun Request for Bid (RFB)
Note: 1. Any corrigendum / addendum to the above package shall be uploaded on the website UK Tenders Portal (www.uktenders.gov.in)
2. For any clarification or information, bidders may contact via email at procurement.uprepare@gmail.com
Program Director

PUNJAB STATE WAREHOUSING CORPORATION
SCO 74-75, BANK SQUARE, SECTOR-17B CHANDIGARH
PBX: 0172-5197847, 5197846
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
PSWC invites online tenders through GeM Portal for creation of 1.35 LMT godown capacities at 02 locations in the State of Punjab for guaranteed lease of 10 years on Build, Own and Operate/Lease basis for storage requirements of FCI under two bid system 'Technical Bid' and 'Financial Bid'.
NIT (alongwith GeM Bid IDs) is available on Department's website i.e., https://pswc.in
PSWC reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason and PSWC will not be held liable for any costs and consequences incurred by the intending bidders.
Note: Any corrigendum(s)/Notification(s) to this Notice Inviting E-Tender shall be published Department's website & GeM Portal.
1004/12/2025-26/9630 Managing Director, PSWC
UDAIPUR SMART CITY LIMITED
Abhay Command and Control Centre Building, Nagar Nigam, Town Hall, Udaipur (Rajasthan) 313001
Tel: 0294-2425325, Website: www.udaipursmartcity.in Email: usc2016@gmail.com
NIT No.:- USCL/2025-26/717 Date:- 13/03/2026
Notice Inviting Bid
The Bid for the "Project Management Consultant for Assisting the Udaipur Smart City Limited to Design, Develop, Manage and Implementation of projects of USCL" of Rs. 242.68 Lac of procurement, invited from interested bidders upto 06s-04-2026 at 06.55 PM. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.raj.nic.) of the state.
UBN No. UNP2526SLOB00172
Raj.Samwadi/C/25/22678 Chief Executive Officer
कार्यालय अधिशाषी अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, विद्युत खण्ड, बीकानेर
अन्य/विद्युत खण्ड/बी./निविदा/2025-26/1861 दिनांक:- 10.03.2026
अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 53/वर्ष 2025-26
(NIB Code No: PWD2526A6085)
निम्न हस्ताक्षरकर्ता द्वारा राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से विद्युत निविदा प्रक्रिया के लिए मोटरबन्द निविदा सूचना, राज. में सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदकों से आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रक्रिया की प्रति अप्रोक्सिमेटिव के कार्यालय में निविदा आवेदन/डाउनलोड करने की दिनांक 11.03.2026 से 18.03.2026 तक सत्र 6.00 बजे तक जमा कराई जा सकती है। तकनीकी निविदा दिनांक 19.03.2026 को प्रात 11.00 बजे खोली जायेगी। प्रो-विड मॉडिंग की दिनांक 16.03.2026 दोपहर 01.00 बजे है। निविदा की अन्य शर्तें एवं स्वीकृत तकनीक और का विवरण किसी भी कार्य दिवस के दौरान इस कार्यालय में उपस्थित होकर देखा जा सकता है। अन्य शर्तें व विवरण इस कार्यालय में व डीपीआर की वेबसाइट www.dipronline.org, http://sppp.raj.nic.in पर देखा जा सकता है। कुल कार्य की संख्या 1 कुल लागत 229.00 लाख
UBN No: 1. PWD2526WSOB25348
भरवदी (मनोज कुमार रायत)
DIPR/C/5315/2026 अधिशाषी अभियन्ता, सा.नि.वि. विद्युत खण्ड, बीकानेर

Men in Blue – a T20 behemoth

India's brand of cricket at the 2026 World Cup was something to be proud of; the current flavour of the season will be Suryakumar and Gambhir, but it should be remembered that the ball was set rolling by Rohit and Dravid, under whom India ended their 17-year wait for a World Cup title

R. Kaushik

A couple of hours after Tilak Varma held the catch that crowned India T20 World Cup winners for an unprecedented third time, head coach Gautam Gambhir arrived with Suryakumar Yadav, who was proudly holding the trophy, to discharge his media responsibilities. Despite the lateness of the hour - Sunday had given way to Monday - there was no sign of restlessness or irritation amongst the usually restless and irritable media corps. Contrary to what many, even within the team environs, might believe, journalists aren't impervious to results; most rejoice when the team wins and are openly disappointed when the results don't go the Indian side's way, and this was clearly a night of celebration, a night to applaud a magnificent campaign either side of a blip against South Africa.

Gambhir carries the not unfounded reputation of being grumpy and snappy at press conferences, often not even waiting for the questioner to complete his query before launching into a reply that might not have any direct relevance to what the question would have been had the head coach been a little more patient. Of course, one can't entirely blame him because several questions are couched at the end of a long discourse from said questioners, but we digress.

Understandably, Gambhir was gung-ho. He might not admit as much, but this World Cup triumph would have come as a soothing balm, a vindication of his methodologies and his philosophies. Gambhir was under public (and perhaps self-imposed) pressure coming into the tournament; in his brief tenure, he has overseen two crushing home series Test defeats. Given that India hadn't lost at home in the preceding dozen years, two routs in 12 months will remain a millstone around his neck, no matter what happens from here on.

Fear of losing

The former opener, combative and intrepid, held forth on eschewing the fear of losing, especially when it came to T20s, adding that it was that fear which often resulted in defeats. "The most important thing in this format was that we didn't want to be afraid of losing, because if you are afraid of losing, you never win," he thundered. "I always believe that high risk, high reward is very important in this format. I would have been happier if we had been out at 110-120. But our target was always to make 250 runs. But we didn't want to play the 160-180 runs cricket. For too long, we played cricket with 160-170 runs. But for the last two years, it was the captain's philosophy, the captain's ideology - the captain himself wanted to play high risk, high reward."

Most of what Gambhir said was indisputably correct. But it isn't only in the last two years that India's philosophy has changed. And the duo that initiated the change was the one that ended the country's prolonged wait for a T20 World Cup crown even though India boasted the most visible and high-profile T20 franchise tournament in the universe.

Against all odds, and perhaps thriving on the supreme lack of expectations, India went all the way in the inaugural T20 World Cup in South Africa, back in 2007. Heading into the tournament, India had played exactly one T20 International, the previous December in South Africa which they won. The squad was without several stalwarts - then Test and ODI skipper Rahul Dravid, champion bat Sachin Tendulkar and Dravid's predecessor Sourav Ganguly foremost among the absentees. There was a surprise first-time captain (Mahendra Singh Dhoni) even though the team had experienced hands in Virender Sehwag and Yuvraj Singh, among others. Dhoni's band played a glorious brand of cricket, using the might of their batting and the assistance in Durban to their pace-orientated attack before subduing Pakistan in the final in Johannesburg to come home to a spectacular reception.

Just how much importance the administrators gave the World Cup, in which India were reluctant participants almost browbeaten into confirming their entry, is evident from the grand launch of the Indian Premier League midway through the team's campaign. The World Cup was viewed as a mere obligation to fulfil, but it proved to be the perfect springboard from which the IPL took off because all of a sudden after the magic in South Africa, the format captured and held the imagination of new audiences while continuing to stay relevant with the pre-existing fans.

The IPL was expected to trigger a slew of title-winning runs, but that wasn't the case, evidently. The more India's players became familiar with the challenges and demands of the 20-over game, the more every campaign was disappointing



Takes two to tango: Dravid joined forces with Rohit to trigger a turnaround in India's T20 fortunes after the 2021 World Cup debacle. The Gambhir-Suryakumar partnership has continued the good work. ANI & ICC

because it didn't produce the right result. India had to wait seven more years and three editions when they didn't even make the knockouts for their next appearance in the final, in 2014 when they were hammered by Sri Lanka in Mirpur. They thereafter continued to flatter to deceive, bowling out in the semifinal in Mumbai in 2016 to West Indies and crashing out of the delayed next edition, in the UAE in 2021, in the first round after dispiriting losses in their first two games to Pakistan and New Zealand respectively.

The desert misadventure was Ravi Shastri's last assignment as the India head coach and Virat Kohli's final engagement as the country's T20I captain. Shastri was succeeded by Dravid, Kohli by Rohit Sharma and this was the catalyst for India shedding conservatism and embracing the enterprise and fearlessness which is an absolute non-negotiable in the 20-over game.

Change of approach

The Gambhir quotes presented a few paragraphs previously are so easily attributable to Dravid, and perhaps with greater reason. Clearly, in 2021, India were seized by the fear of losing. Their batting, especially, lacked creativity and imagination; the onus was on building an innings, keeping wickets in hand and then trying to explode at the end, which might have worked wonders in 50-over cricket at one point, but which is the very antithesis of how to approach a 120-ball innings. Gambhir said the 'high risk high reward' ideology was the captain's. Guess what? It was his predecessor, Rohit, who was the poster boy of the 'high risk high reward' approach, setting the tone with his selfless assaults as an opener and therefore erasing the necessity to tell the others what to do because when you put your money where your mouth is, you don't need to ask others to contribute, do you?

India's scoring rates undertook a

dramatic upswing in the immediacy of the Rohit-Dravid leadership group forming an unexpectedly awesome pair of opposites united by several common threads. It's often wrongly perceived that India's 20-over philosophy changed dramatically after their crushing ten-wicket loss to England in the semifinal of the World Cup in Adelaide in November 2022. But the die had been cast long before that, as Dravid told this writer a couple of months after the 2024 World Cup triumph.

"People use that semifinal as a changing point but honestly, in our first meetings itself, we were on the same page that we needed to change the way we were playing T20 cricket," Dravid had pointed out. "If you notice our scores from, say, the UAE World Cup to the T20 World Cup in Australia, you'd see a marked difference. The wheels had started to turn well before that semifinal loss. That England loss was a disappointment, perhaps the conditions suited England more. But we were moving in that direction (of aggressive batting) well before that (Australia) World Cup. And we continued that into the 50-over World Cup, Rohit led that beautifully."

Rohit had four T20I centuries from 111 innings when he became the T20I captain, and added just one more in his 40 hits as the leader, but even though his average dropped by nearly five runs during that phase, his strike-rate went up and he did the tough job, irrespective of the conditions or the opposition, without complaint. After all, how could he complain when it was his idea in the first place, you say? What makes it all the more remarkable is that for more than 14 months, between the Adelaide loss to England in November 2022 and home series against Afghanistan in January 2024 - India's last outings before the World Cup in the Americas - he didn't play a single T20I with the focus shifting to the 50-over home World Cup in October-November 2023. To lose none of his T20 nous and

reel off a fifth century, more than five years after his fourth, was a huge personal triumph for the captain who then ran a fabulous ship during the 2024 World Cup.

Gambhir was graceful in dedicating the title to, among others, 'Rahul *bhai* for everything he's done during his tenure to keep Indian cricket in such a good shape.' At the same time, he held forth on not merely inheriting a successful team but also in creating something. "Hopefully, we've created something which all of you guys could be proud of, the brand of cricket we've played."

India's brand of cricket at the 2026 World Cup was something to be proud of. There was a 160-run innings (161/9), something Gambhir hates (his words, not ours) in the very first outing against United States, but it's a sign of how high this side has raised the bar that subsequent efforts of 209, 175 and 193 while batting first on less than perfect batting strips were seen as underwhelming. After the Ahmedabad meltdown (India were dismissed for 111, their lowest World Cup total), a return to flat surfaces brought the best out of the Indian batting. In three of their last four matches, India batted first and responded with totals of 256, 253 and 255; in the virtual quarterfinal before the last two efforts of 250-plus, they scaled down West Indies' 195 at Eden Gardens with reasonable comfort. Now, that's what we are talking about.

Jasprit Bumrah has shown that even two overs of exceptional bowling is more influential in deciding the outcome of a tight contest (the semifinal against England) than a string of fours and sixes, but the T20 format will continue to remain a batter's game and that's where India have grabbed the lead. The current flavour of the season will be Suryakumar and Gambhir, as they should be, but let's not lose sight of the fact that the ball was set rolling by Rohit and Dravid, under whom India ended their 17-year wait for a World Cup title.

THE GIST

Gambhir was under public (and perhaps self-imposed) pressure coming into the tournament; in his brief tenure, he has overseen two crushing home series Test defeats. Given that India hadn't lost at home in the preceding dozen years, two routs in 12 months in Test series will remain a millstone around his neck, no matter what happens from here on

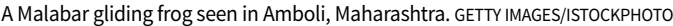
The IPL was expected to trigger a slew of title-winning runs, but that wasn't the case, evidently. The more India's players became familiar with the challenges and demands of the 20-over game, the more every campaign was disappointing because it didn't produce the right result

Bumrah has shown that even two overs of exceptional bowling is more influential in deciding the outcome of a tight contest than a string of fours and sixes, but the T20 format will continue to remain a batter's game and that's where India have grabbed the lead

India's frogs find allies from citizen science to sanctuaries

Karthikeyan Vasudevan

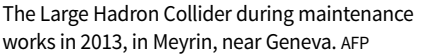
In fact, India hosts a significant share of the world's 'data deficient' amphibian



The breeding activity is focused on producing many tadpoles, which then engorge themselves on the luxuriant growth of algae in water bodies and grow quickly. They metamorphose into small froglets and hop on the land. In this phase, many lose out as they become

There have also been more success stories of late. These include the Mapping Malabar Tree Toad Project, a citizen science project, coordinated by K.V. Gururaja in the Western Ghats; the Amphibian Recovery Project by S. Harikrishnan of the Wildlife Trust of India in Munnar, Kerala, with the Kanan Devan

(Karthikeyan Vasudevan is a Chief Scientist at the CSIR-Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology, Hyderabad. He is a herpetologist who works on amphibian disease ecology. karthik.ccmdb@csir.res.in)



Large Hadron Collider discovers a new particle

The Hindu Bureau

To chase them down, the Large

The new particle has been named “Xi-cc-plus” and scientists hope that the particle – which is similar to a proton but four times heavier – will reveal more about quantum mechanics

The Large Hadron Collider is a 27-km long proton-smashing ring running 100 metres below France and Switzerland. Famously, it proved the existence of the Higgs boson – known colloquially as the “God particle” – in 2012.

(With inputs from AFP)

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Metaphors from science that are used in conflicts

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

_____ is the point at which a policy or insurgency becomes self-sustaining. In nuclear physics, it's the minimum amount of fissile material required to maintain a nuclear chain reaction. The metaphor alludes to a system technically transitioning from a stable state to a self-propelling one. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 2

X is a metaphor for removing entrenched corruption or a hidden class of bureaucrats but which in history was used to eliminate the breeding grounds of vectors, like mosquitoes, and so stop the spread of malaria and yellow fever. Name X.

QUESTION 3

To do this is to destroy a region so thoroughly that an opponent can never return to power or rebuild there. Taken literally, it refers to when a high concentration of sodium chloride in the soil draws water out of plant roots through osmosis, dehydrating them from the inside. What is it?

QUESTION 4

Biologists say a substance is ' _____' if it interferes with the internal balance of a living organism, leading to harm or death. But in policy circles, it refers to environments or assets so poisonous that they threaten the health of institutions. Fill in the blank.

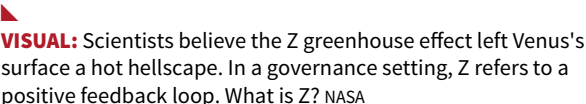
QUESTION 5

In chemistry, Y is the lowest temperature at which a liquid yields enough vapour to form an ignitable

mixture in the air — meaning at this point, the environment is primed for combustion. In the context of war, Y is where a specific area is likely to erupt into sudden and violent conflict. Name Y.

Answers to March 17 quiz:

1. 1977 Spielberg film culminating at Devil's Tower – **Ans: Close Encounters of the Third Kind**
 2. 1997 adaptation of a Carl Sagan novel – **Ans: Contact**
 3. 1990 film exploring use of L-DOPA to revive encephalitis lethargica patients – **Ans: Awakenings**
 4. 1983 following the Mercury Seven pilots – **Ans: The Right Stuff**
 5. Film exploring the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, non-linear time – **Ans: Arrival**
- Visual:** Douglas Trumbull
- First contact: Tamal Biswas | K.N. Viswanathan | Prem Nath Tiwari | Appa Rao M.V. | Soumit Chakraborty



Please send in your answers to
science@thehindu.co.in

For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to
science@thehindu.co.in with the
subject 'Daily page'

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Record number of inbound tourists who visited Japan in Feb.

3.46 in million. Visitors to Japan in February rose 6.4% from a year earlier to set a new record for the month, despite a drop-off in Chinese tourists amid ongoing diplomatic tensions between the two countries. REUTERS

Number of deaths of children under five in 2024

4.9 in million. About 4.9 million children under five died in 2024, according to new United Nations estimates. Most of the deaths were preventable with better access to healthcare and low-cost interventions for challenges. AP

Displacements of Palestinians in the West Bank

36,000 A report by the UN warned that Israel's accelerating expansion and annexation of large parts of the West Bank was driving "unprecedented" displacement. AFP

Telegram channels disabled for hosting pirated content

3,142 More than 3,100 Telegram channels and about 800 websites hosting pirated content have been disabled at the government's order, the Lok Sabha was informed on Wednesday. PTI

Number of backlogs of consumer cases between 2020-24

5.15 in lakh. The Consumer Justice Report prepared by the India Justice Report (IJR) said that between 2020 and 2024, the pendency of cases increased by 21%, from 87,545 to 5.15 lakh. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us [facebook.com/thehindu](#) [X.com/the_hindu](#) [instagram.com/the_hindu](#)

What is new in transgender rights Bill?

How is the government proposing to alter the definition of 'transgender person'? What is the right to self-perceived gender identity? What does the new Bill propose on gender certification and SRS? Why are transgender communities opposing the amendments?

EXPLAINER

Abhinav Lakshman

The story so far:

Twelve years after the Supreme Court recognised the transgender identity and held that "self-determination of gender is an integral part of personal autonomy and self-expression", falling within the realm of personal liberty guaranteed by the Constitution of India, the Union government on March 13 introduced a Bill in the Lok Sabha to take away transgender people's "right to self-perceived gender identity" and redefine a "transgender person" by proposing amendments to the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019. Transgender community leaders, activists, and people across the country reacted with shock, arguing that the amendments go against the fundamental principles underlying their long struggle for recognition.

What are the changes being brought about?

The key changes being proposed have to do with the definition of a "transgender person" and the expansion of the section on offences against transgender people and punishments for them.

In the amendment Bill, the Centre has called for the omission of sub-section (2) of Section 4 of the Act, which says: "A person recognised as transgender under sub-section (1) shall have a right to self-perceived gender identity."

In addition to this, a new definition of 'transgender person' is proposed. It describes them as people "having such socio-cultural identities as kinner, hijra, aravani, and jogta, or eunuch", people with intersex variations, and people who have "congenital variations" in "male or female development" in their "primary sexual characteristics, external genitalia, chromosomal patterns, gonadal development, endogenous hormone production or response or such other medical conditions".

The definition also includes any person or child who has been "compelled to assume, adopt, or outwardly present a transgender identity, by mutilation, emasculation, castration, amputation, or any surgical, chemical, or hormonal procedure or otherwise". However, it adds that this definition shall not include "persons with different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities".

Compared to this definition, the Act currently defines transgender person as someone "whose gender does not match with the gender assigned at birth and includes trans men and trans women (whether or not such person has undergone Sex Reassignment Surgery (SRS) or hormone therapy or laser therapy or such other therapy), person with intersex variations, genderqueer and person having such socio-cultural identities as kinner, hijra, aravani and jogta."

Further, a specific definition for "people with intersex variations" has also been proposed to be omitted.

Apart from these, the Bill suggests introducing the terminology for "authority", defining it as "a medical board, headed by a Chief Medical Officer or a Deputy Chief Medical Officer, as may be appointed by the Central government, State government or Union territory Administration".

Another key amendment is on the issuance of transgender certificates. While the law currently mandates the District Magistrate to issue a certificate based on a self-declared affidavit and without



Activists and members of the community during a demonstration against the Bill on Wednesday. AFP

physical or medical examination, the proposed amendment requires the District Magistrate to "examine the recommendation of the authority", and decide, if deemed necessary or desirable, and after consulting other medical experts, before issuing the certificate.

A new section has also been proposed, which confers the right of transgender people to have their first names changed in birth certificates and other identification documents, with the caveat that the person should be a "transgender person" under the revised definition.

The Bill also mandates that individuals apply for a revised gender certificate after undergoing SRS, as opposed to the current law, which leaves this to the individual.

Additionally, medical institutions performing SRS would be required to furnish details of such procedures to the District Magistrate.

The Bill also significantly expands provisions relating to offences and penalties, introducing graded punishments, including rigorous imprisonment up to life and fines of up to ₹5 lakh, for crimes against transgender persons and children.

However, it remains to be seen what further changes could come through in the form of Rules, if this amendment Bill is passed by Parliament.

How did the amendment Bill come about?

Union Social Justice Minister Virendra Kumar introduced the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, in Lok Sabha on March 13. Days earlier, media reports cited that the Union Cabinet had approved amendments to the 2019 Act, though details were not disclosed. It remains unclear how long the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment and the Centre had been preparing these changes.

Transgender activists, including Tamil Nadu-based Grace Banu, who had been central to the drafting of the 2019 Act, told *The Hindu* that the amendments seem to have been brought in without consultation with the community. Several leaders and members have described their initial reaction as one of "shock", calling the changes "sudden".

Interestingly, just hours before the Bill was introduced, the Ministry had posted on X, promoting the 2019 version of the Act and advertising the fact that this Act allowed the right to self-perceived gender identity as a key feature.

A few days back, on March 4, the Ministry had posted, "The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, safeguards the rights and dignity of transgender persons."

In February, the National Council for Educational Research and Training (NCERT) informed the Supreme Court that it had developed teacher training modules to build sensitivity towards transgender issues.

It substantiated this by saying that the 2024 module specifically spoke of the difference between gender and sexuality and discussed the idea that sex identity ascribed at birth may be at odds with a person's perceived sex identity at a later stage. The NCERT added that it had been conducting capacity building and training programmes based on similar modules till as late as November 2025, with more planned this year.

Why is there a concern?

A primary concern raised by the transgender community is the omission of the right to self-perceived gender identity, followed by the new definition, which appears to contradict the principles laid down in the landmark 2014 NALSA judgment recognising the right to self-determination of gender.

Ms. Banu said, "there is an issue that the government seems to be including only those in the definition of transgender who may have been accommodated in Hindutva's history and is using terms that indicate Hindutva's accommodation of transgender identity like 'hijra, kinner, aravani,' etc." And there seems to be some sort of refusal to use respectful terms that have evolved for transgender people in other parts of the country, like in Tamil Nadu, where there is now a vocabulary of *thirunagai* and *thirunambi*.

Dr. Aqsa Shaikh has raised the issue of transgender people across the country having to now deal with the existential question of whether they continue to remain transgender as per the proposed new definition, while another Delhi-based transwoman spoke of concerns that this might create divides within the community about who has legitimacy to use the transgender identity.

What does the NALSA judgment say?

The landmark 2014 judgment in *National Legal Services Authority vs Union of India*, delivered by Justices K.S. Radhakrishnan and A.K. Sikri, remains central to India's understanding of gender identity.

When the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Bill, 2019, was introduced, the Statement of Objects and Reasons in it noted that it flowed from this very judgment of the Supreme Court, adding that one of the principal goals of bringing this Bill was to "confer right upon transgender persons to be recognised as such, and a right to self-perceived gender identity". In the judgment that notably

recognised a third gender beyond male and female, and the fundamental right of persons to self-determination of gender identity, the court accepted the principle that the concepts of gender and sexuality are different and that gender identity is on a spectrum.

The court said, "Gender identity is one of the most fundamental aspects of life which refers to a person's intrinsic sense of being male, female or transgender or transsexual persons."

The judgment explained that "a person's sex is usually assigned at birth, but a relatively small group of persons may be born with bodies which incorporate both or certain aspects of both male and female physiology. At times, genital anatomy problems may arise in certain persons and their innate perception of themselves is not in conformity with the sex assigned to them at birth and may include pre and post-operative transsexual persons and also persons who do not choose to undergo or do not have access to operation and also includes persons who cannot undergo successful operations."

On sexual orientation, the court defined it as an individual's enduring emotional, romantic, or physical attraction to others.

Importantly, the court held that no person should be forced to undergo medical procedures – such as SRS, sterilisation, or hormone therapy – as a condition for legal recognition of their gender identity.

It concluded that self-determination of gender is integral to personal autonomy, dignity, and freedom under Article 21 of the Constitution.

Justice Sikri, in his judgment concurring with Justice Radhakrishnan, expanded on this, saying, "If democracy is based on the recognition of the individuality and dignity of man, as a fortiori we have to recognise the right of a human being to choose his sex/gender identity which is integral to his/her personality and is one of the most basic aspects of self-determination, dignity and freedom."

What is the government's reasoning?

In the Statement of Objects and Reasons, the government said that since the 2019 Act was enacted, "certain doubts and difficulties" have arisen in implementing it with regard to the "definition of transgender persons and how the identification of such persons is to be done".

It noted that the existing definition of "transgender person" was "vague", arguing that this made it "impossible to identify the genuine oppressed persons to whom the benefits of the Act are intended to reach". It added that this existing definition renders several provisions "unworkable", further saying that this definition was "not compatible" with several statutory provisions enacted by both Parliament and State legislatures.

The government has argued that the intent of the legislative policy was always to "protect only those who face severe social exclusion due to biological reasons" for no fault or choice of their own. It went on to say that the purpose of the legislation was never to "protect each and every class of persons with various gender identities, self-perceived sex/gender identities or gender fluidities".

Noting these aspects, the government argued for a "precise" definition of transgender people, saying, "The protection and benefits that are provided under the Act are vast in nature, and therefore, care has to be taken that such identification cannot be extended on the basis of any acquirable characteristics or personal choice or claimed self-perceived identity of an individual."

THE GIST

The Amendment Bill proposes removing the 'right to self-perceived gender identity' and introducing a new definition of a 'transgender person', focusing on socio-cultural identities, intersex variations, and congenital conditions.

It introduces a medical board-led certification process, requires scrutiny by the District Magistrate, mandates a revised certificate after SRS, and expands provisions on offences and punishments.

Transgender activists argue the changes contradict the NALSA judgment on self-determination of gender, could exclude sections of the community, and have been brought without consultation.

